UNLEASHING CREATIVE CAMPAIGNS

A TOOLKIT

FROM THE CENTER FOR ARTISTIC ACTIVISM

UNLEASHING CREATIVE CAMPAIGNS:

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ARTISTIC ACTIVISM

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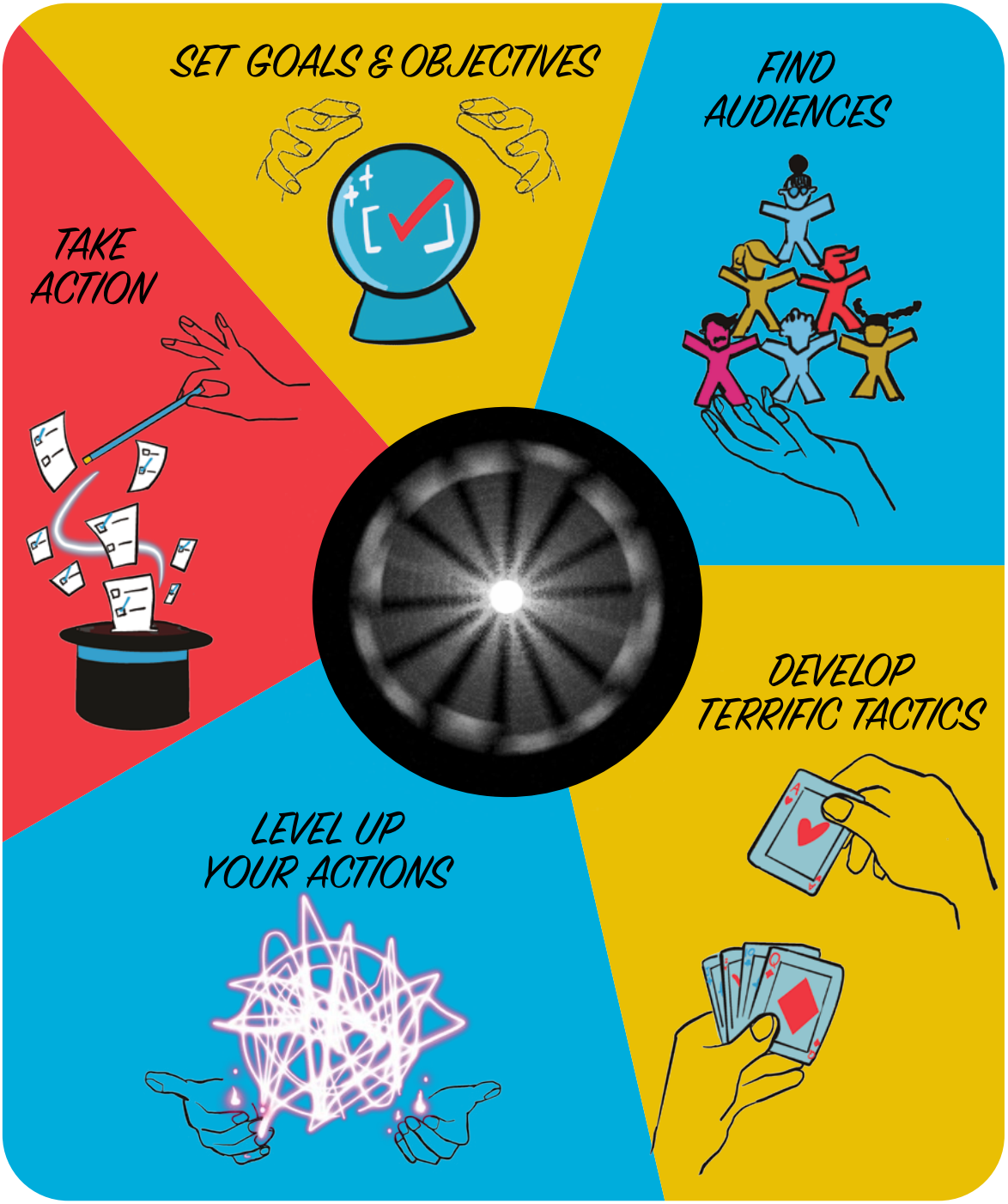
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INTRODUCTION



Hello!

Imagination powers change—and changes power. At the **Center for Artistic Activism**, we help create change through rigorous methodology and irresistible interventions. Our research, tools, and trainings give organizations, activists, artists, funders, and everyone in between the tools they need to win campaigns and win them big.

Whether you're the leader of a national movement organization, an individual activist, or someone looking to make the world just a little bit better, we want you to have and use ideas and tools that work. To that end, we conduct trainings for you to participate in, build communities for you to join, and write special guides for you to use—like this toolkit.

WHY A TOOLKIT?

We want to put the resources you need at your fingertips, so we took years of insights and collected them here. You'll find methods and techniques we've learned while working with advocates and activists of all stripes in the U.S. and around the world.

This toolkit has **exercises, tools, and stories** to help you move forward at different points in your campaign process. **We encourage you to read through it front to back.** It can also be used when you and your team need some extra inspiration or if you're stuck at a particular moment in your process.



Activists and artists in London, England create a parade to advocate for free global access to COVID vaccines.

WHAT IS A CREATIVE CAMPAIGN?

By **campaign**, we mean a concerted effort to make some improvement in the world. There's a dreamy, even utopic, long-term goal you hope to achieve in your lifetime, and your campaign involves shorter-term efforts that move in that direction.

A creative campaign uses creativity throughout its development and implementation.

This can look vastly different campaign to campaign. Often, the most externally visible aspects are tactics that draw upon the powers of signs, symbols, story, and spectacle to **move people emotionally—which prepares them to move politically**.

But it's not just about externally facing tactics. It's also about **bringing a creative approach to everything**: from how you set goals, objectives, strategies; to how you structure an organization; to how you organize the dynamics of group meetings; and beyond. Creativity and innovation are only fully leveraged when they are integrated into the entire campaign, not just in a few flashy tactics.

The Creative Campaign Checklist on the next page will give you a sense of the components of a campaign and how this toolkit helps with each of them. On the right, you'll find which chapter of this toolkit to use to help guide you. **Get a copy of this checklist online at** c4aa.org/kit/checklist2**.**

RESOURCE

CREATIVE CAMPAIGN CHECKLIST

Campaign Component	Toolkit Chapter
☐ **Utopic Goal**	**Step 1:** Set Goals + Objectives Page 15
☐ **SMARTIE Objective(s)**	**Step 1:** Set Goals + Objectives Page 24
☐ **Primary Audience**	**Step 2:** Find Audiences Page 30
☐ **Think Feel Do**	**Step 2:** Find Audiences Page 33
☐ **Audience Personas**	**Step 2:** Find Audiences Page 34
☐ **Cost-Benefit Analysis**	**Step 2:** Find Audiences Page 36
☐ **Cultural Terrain Analysis**	**Step 2:** Find Audiences Page 42
☐ **At Least 10 Tactic Ideas**	**Step 3:** Develop Terrific Tactics Page 45
☐ **Selected Tactics(s)**	**Step 3:** Develop Terrific Tactics Page 49
☐ **Enhanced Tactic(s)** that are more celebratory, hopeful, joyous, mysterious, whimsical, surprising, irresistible, spectacular, personal, risky, innovative, participatory, interactive…	**Step 4:** Level Up Your Actions Page 52
☐ **Prototyped Tactic(s)**	**Step 5:** Take Action Page 59
☐ **Evaluation Plan**	**Step 5:** Take Action Page 62
☐ **Assessment Methods**	**Step 5:** Take Action Page 62
☐ **Iteration and Plans for the Future**	**Step 5:** Take Action Page 69
☐ **Celebration and Continuation**	**Step 5:** Take Action Page 71

WHY CREATIVE CAMPAIGNS WIN

Creativity is crucial because creative approaches to campaigning combine the **affective**—or emotional—power of the arts with the **effective**—or directly impactful—capabilities of activism. We made up a word for this combination of affect and effect: **æffect**. Æffect is an exceptionally powerful combination because it does far more than what art or activism can do alone. (We have excellent examples ahead, and you can check out Actipedia.org for thousands of user-submitted examples of æffective activism, too.)

Æffective strategies inherently foster fresh ways to solve intractable problems. Repeating past strategies and tactics can make your team predictable to the opposition and easier to outmaneuver and dismiss. Instead, creative campaigns can be **surprising**, slip **under the radar**, make our work more **sustainable**, and are often more **strategic** than traditional activism.

SURPRISING:

Creative campaigns can show up in unlikely places (e.g., not just outside government offices) and take unfamiliar forms (e.g., beyond a march or protest). They can take **forms that aren't immediately recognized as political**, and they can **bypass people's pre-conceived notions** of both activism and art along with predetermined ideas about the issues and their players. Taken by surprise, hearts can be touched and minds can be reached—and both can be changed. **Creative campaigns can catch people off guard. In those moments, you have a higher likelihood of changing their beliefs and behaviors, and they're more likely to remember it later.**

UNDER THE RADAR:

Authorities who would otherwise shut down a political action just aren't sure what to do with a creative campaign. They can't easily be identified as "political." They may be perceived as "aesthetic," which authorities might not notice in the same way. In this liminal space, **creative campaigns can evade restriction and effectively communicate a socio-political message to the public**.

SUSTAINABLE:

Activism and the arts go together. They always have. Classifying creativity and experimentation as un-serious or superfluous can drain the lifeblood from a campaign and ultimately your organization. Instead of turning comrades into cogs, **allow members of your team to bring more of their humanity into their work. The people involved are more energized, joyful, focused, and resilient**, and their collaborators, partners, and audiences feel more connected and excited about opportunities to engage. This can last for years, sustaining enthusiasm and energy for the cause over time.

STRATEGIC:

Creative methods can reveal **multiple solutions** to problems and **new pathways** to achieve your objectives. In advocacy campaigns, there are many decades-old methods to reach and engage audiences—tabling, canvassing, op-ed writing, etc. These methods certainly can and do yield results, but are they the best way? **Creative campaigns encourage big brainstorming, non-linear thinking, exploration, and fresh, unconventional approaches.** Through generating other perspectives and multiple ideas, those with stronger potential can emerge.

Creative campaigners know there are many variables on the journey from an exciting plan to a campaign victory, and they consciously leverage the creative process to increase their chances of succeeding. Quick sketches, multiple iterations, experimentation, testing, and a spirit of play—along with strategic risk-taking and bouncing back from failures and setbacks—are crucial parts of the process. **By drawing from artistic, design, and cultural practices, the work will be more effective, resonant, and collaborative. And also: more fun.**

→ For stories of some of our favorite artistic activism campaigns, head to **Stories of Creative Campaigns** at c4aa.org/kit/stories.



Public health activists in Dublin, Ireland, delight holiday shoppers while winning support for sex worker rights.

A SERIOUS NOTE ON THE IMPORTANCE OF FUN

Integrating creativity makes our work more enjoyable, and it can also lead to campaigns that are more exciting, attractive, and relatable to audiences, staff, and volunteers.

We've worked on extremely difficult issues and have always been surprised how our collaborators find ways to successfully use humor, games, utopian visions, surprising stories, and fun tactics no matter how dire the circumstances. Whether public-facing or internal, we've seen how important (and radical) it is to keep a space for joy and fun in every single campaign. **We always need to be sensitive, but that doesn't mean we always need to be deadly serious.**

RISKS OF NOT CENTERING CREATIVITY AND INNOVATION

- Repeated methods lose efficacy
- While our opponents innovate, we lag behind
- We don't get the full benefit of the skills and talents of the team
- Advocacy becomes a chore, and there's increased burnout

WHAT IF I'M NOT CREATIVE?

Some people feel intimidated when asked to use creativity in their work. But **creativity is something you already possess**. It's something all human beings have and use all the time.

Also: **creativity comes from combination**. Don't torture yourself trying to come up with "An Entirely New Idea." It doesn't work that way. New ideas emerge by putting together elements from things that already exist in new ways. Take African rhythms and call-and-response and European melodies and hymns. Mix them together on a new continent and in new contexts, and what do you have? A wealth of musical culture: gospel, blues, country, jazz, soul, rock 'n' roll, reggae, hip-hop, and on and on. A whole lineage of musical styles coming from music that existed before.

HOW THE TOOLKIT CAN HELP NAVIGATE AROUND PARTICULAR CHALLENGES

Challenge: We're having trouble **coming up with clear objectives**.

See **Step 1** for detailed and time-tested ways to create specific, achievable objectives that will work best in your campaign.

Challenge: **We want to be creative**, but we don't know where to start.

Spoiler alert: you are already creative, every day—and we have ways to help you tap into that. This entire toolkit has exercises and ideas to help you and your team integrate creativity into your process.

→ To jumpstart your team's creativity, check out the **Uncovering Creativity** and **Creativity from Combination** exercises at c4aa.org/kit/creativity.

Challenge: We've got the makings of a campaign, but **it's missing something**. How do we bring it over the top?

See **Step 4** for tools to ramp up your campaign and take it to the next level.

Challenge: We do actions and campaigns but struggle to know what impact they have. **How can we best assess** what we're doing?

See **Step 5** for ideas that might be new to you when it comes to assessment and evaluation.

THE CREATIVE PROCESS

It can be helpful to understand how creative processes generally work before making a creative campaign. Once you know the steps, it's much easier to understand how to move through them and pinpoint potential obstacles that may have impeded your progress in the past.

1. OBSERVER: RESEARCH

No one creates new things—we just create new combinations of things that came before. Even the most innovative thinkers aren't thinking entirely "new" thoughts; they are curious about the world, collecting inspiration, and making new connections between what already exists.

In order to make new combinations, we need to seek out and gather inspiration from diverse sources. We must observe and explore.

Creative exploration means moving through the world with wonder and observing without judgment. We all collect things that capture our imagination, that we draw upon and refer back to—the books on your shelf, photos on your phone, notebooks you keep, and people you meet. Your discoveries when observing the world include everything you take notice of: movies you went to (and hated) or TV you feel guilty about watching (and more guilty about enjoying). Experiences of all types serve as points of inspiration we can draw from in the next step of the creative process.

2. INVENTOR: SKETCH

Inventors are always trying to find novel ways to solve problems, and we do the same in the creative process. **We use what we collected as an explorer and make new combinations—still without judgment—** because we're not yet evaluating if and how these work, or if they're even feasible! We're allowing a crucial period for new combinations to emerge and merge into other new combinations.

We do this because when we combine elements they react with one another in new ways, but we don't truly know how they will react until we do it. **Every experiment won't lead to wild success, but each experiment is an essential step** as we refine an idea: the early drafts, the underpainting, the pencil sketch on the back of an envelope. These drafts give us information that increases our odds of success. Every note in a notebook will not become a poem. But the surplus is required for innovation—and sometimes the "scraps" left behind come in handy in the future.

Don't force yourself to think of innovative ideas while also factoring budgets, timelines, and approvals. Allow yourself time apart from spreadsheets and calendars to dream, play, experiment, and see what you discover.

3. CRITIC: EVALUATE

A good coach gives valuable feedback that makes the whole team perform better. They're honest when you're falling short and suggest how to train to improve. When you are ready, they put you in the game and cheer you on as they send you out onto the field.

At this point in the creative process, we've done experiments wherein we deliberately set aside practical concerns to open up the possibilities. **Now it's time for the critic and coach to check our combinations against reality**. Which plans are we ready to move forward with? Which have potential but should return to the lab for more development? Are there improvements we need to make to increase the likelihood of success? Our duty in this stage is to look at what's been made so far and ask: **Will it work for what we want to do?** Looking over our ideas, we ask questions like:

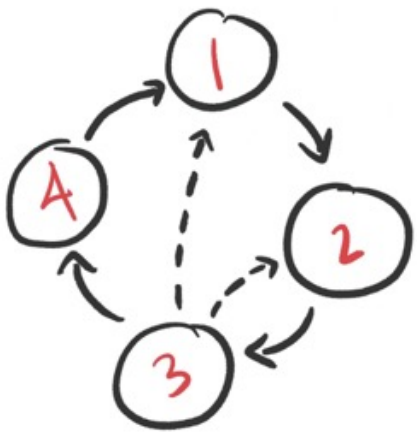
- Do we need to return to the observer role and do more research?
- Do we need to return to the inventor role and generate more ideas? Or a different combination of them?
- Is this plan practical enough? Is it ambitious enough?
- Is it legible to our audience? Will the connections being made be understood by others? Or is it speaking too much only to our own perspective, experience, and ego?
- To what end are we working? Are we still on track? Will this move us toward our goal? Will it be effective? Will it be affective?
- Wait a minute, maybe... is this just wild enough to work???

4. WORKER BEE: ACT

After we get approval from the critic, it's time to put the plan into action. Now **we do whatever it takes to get the job done**. Long days, late hours. Calling in friends, using all 17 rolls of duct tape, breaking open the piggy bank, or breaking—er, bending—some laws; we make it happen.

And the process repeats.

You'll see in the diagram that the process is a circle. Everything we create through the worker bee role becomes part of our exploration in our next observer role, and so on. **The successes, failures, and lessons learned become material we use in the next creative cycle**.

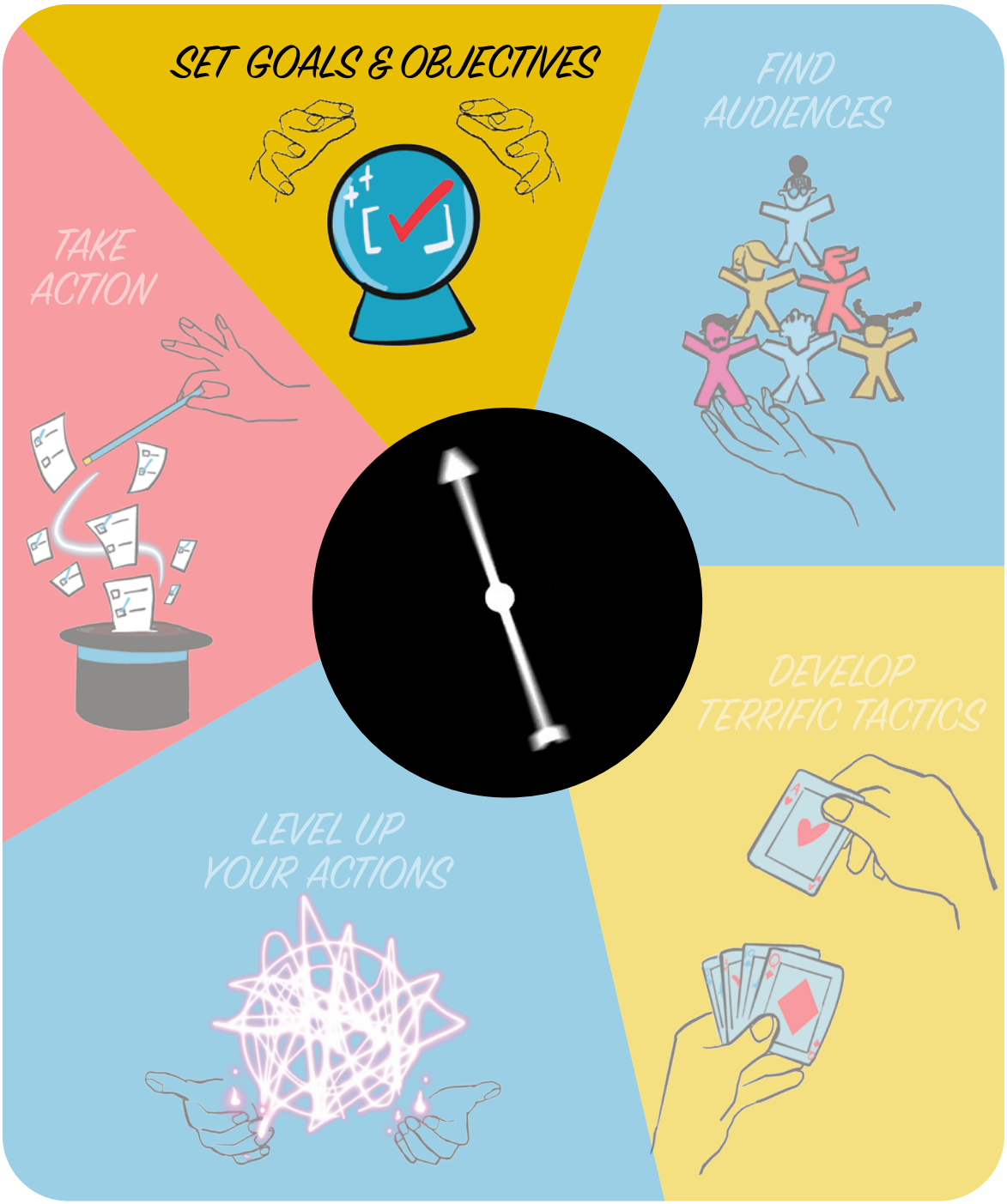


CHECK IN: USING THE CREATIVE PROCESS IN MY CAMPAIGN

Get your colleagues and collaborators together and discuss how you move through the steps of the creative process. Ask yourselves questions like:

- **What are we good at?** Each person and team will have roles that suit them more than others. Where do we shine?
- **What do we spend too much time on?** Where do we linger, or maybe even get stuck? E.g., Do we spend more time than we need on initial research? Do we spend too much time on critical feedback?
- **What could we give more time to?** What do we tend to rush past? E.g., Do we jump to critique before letting ideas really bloom? Do we steamroll through the steps in an attempt to get to an action as quickly as possible? Is all the feedback that's offered negative because there's no time allowed for a more full, constructive conversation?
- **What do we get out of order?** Getting the process balanced and in order allows for all kinds of innovation. But let a critic into your brainstorming session and you'll see how that voice can quickly stifle new ideas before they take shape. Or taking action before you've received enough feedback means you can't take full advantage of insights that could have made the project more successful.
- **What do we not do at all?** You may find you're completely overlooking a step. Some groups don't give any time to explore and discover. Some don't try to make new combinations and simply repeat the old ways over and over. Do a quick check — could your team be overlooking a part of the process?

STEP 1
SET GOALS AND OBJECTIVES





LGBTQIA+ activists in North Macedonia create the utopia they hope for: an inclusive miniature country complete with open, welcome borders and gender-expansive passports.

Preparing for a campaign entails equal parts **utopian dreaming** and **practical planning**. To give our work direction and inspire others (and ourselves), we need to anchor our ambitions to the **dream** of the world we want to win. From there, we set **goals** to help us realize it. Those goals come within reach by identifying specific steps to move us toward them: concrete **objectives**, met through ambitious but achievable **tactics**, and backed up by all those practical details. Together, these make up the **creative campaign**: the map that will move us closer to the utopia we imagine.

The order of the above is purposeful. So often we get caught up in the tiny details of a campaign without ever really seeing—and being able to describe to others—why we care about those details in the first place. So let's start by exploring the utopia that's buried deep in our imaginations.

START WITH UTOPIA, EVEN THOUGH IT DOESN'T EXIST

The kind of world we dream of living and thriving within does not (yet) exist. Yes, your utopia may *never* exist, but that's not the point. Dismissals of utopia misunderstand utopia's fundamental purpose. Utopia, translated, means "no place." **Utopia is not a destination; it's an ideal that provides us a sense of our direction.**

That vision, deep down, is what drives us. It's why we keep going after a setback. It's in all of us because we know how great it could be. So **unlocking creativity means, first, allowing yourself to imagine that ideal world.**

EXERCISE

IMAGINE WINNING

10–15 MIN

In the next few minutes you're going to visit the world you're working to build. This vision will help guide your creative campaign and provide inspiration and direction to your work throughout.

This is one of the key exercises in our workshops, intended to get participants to tap into their utopian dreams of success from the start.

You can do this on your own in a notebook, or if you're working in a group, do the exercise in pairs and share at the end.

1. Think of the **issue you've been working on**, or one you'd like to be working on.

   For example, let's say the issue we're working on is protecting LGBTQIA+ communities in State X from discrimination.

2. Now imagine winning. Imagine what would happen if you had limitless funding, countless volunteers to help you, popular and political support, and everything goes your way. Picture the best case scenario. What would success look like?

3. Sketch out — in words or images — what that win looks like.

   We could imagine winning as: passing a landmark law that makes discrimination and harassment of LGBTQIA+ individuals illegal. State X now has one of the most progressive anti-discrimination laws in the country and reported cases of discrimination against LGBTQIA+ people plummet.

4. Now we're going to challenge your imaginative skills. Picture this: **you have the ability to time-travel**. You see the future, and guess what? You did it! **Everything you described above has happened**. Take a moment and bask in the win. Hold a glass aloft. Put your feet up. Set aside the voices that tell you this is all silly and just allow yourself to dream for a moment. Relax and breathe in the sweet air of victory. It feels good. . . And — you can do more. Your vision of success may be too modest.

5. Go back to your imaginary win, and now that you have that success under your belt, ask yourself, **"What would I do next?"** In our workshops, we've noticed that this is a moment when people tend to tense up, draw a blank, or get embarrassed. It's to be expected: tapping into our dreams of success makes us vulnerable. It's often easier to dwell on what stands in our way than to imagine succeeding. Acknowledge your feelings and move on, because **this is a time to be creative and explore your dreams**. Just think about your next challenge and write out or draw what this would be.

   To continue our example, we can ensure that LGBTQIA+ rights are maintained by electing politicians who represent and support that community.

   Guess what? You accomplished it. You won, again. Congratulations! Now... ask yourself, again, **"What would I do next?"**

   After we succeed in electing LGBTQIA+ politicians at every level of government in State X, success might look like a series of both laws and educational programs that change culture to be accepting and celebratory of all sexualities and genders.

6. **Repeat the step above at least five times and continue until you reach a place where no further wins are possible, and there is nothing more to do.** Work toward a world in which everything you've wanted to do has been achieved. A world in which you can — if you wish — retire from being an activist and spend the rest of your life hiking, traveling the world in a solar-powered RV, or whatever it is you would do if you could. Travel toward the world of your dreams.

   If we keep winning, we can imagine a world in which all genders and sexualities are celebrated and supported, and there is no discrimination at all. Maybe gender as a concept becomes obsolete.

7. You have had success after success. You've made seemingly impossible gains in transforming society for the better. Now, take a moment to **imagine living in this world you've won.** See it in your mind and picture it vividly. Imagine walking around this world. Spend a few minutes thinking about what that world looks, smells, and sounds like.

Acceptance of people of all backgrounds, sexualities, and genders. People walk down the streets to fanfare recognizing all the things that make them unique. With everyone in higher spirits, people have more time and energy to make the world a better place leading to: Clean air and water. Free and accessible healthcare, housing, and education for all. An end to poverty. An end to guns and violence. And so much more. People gathering and feeling safe. So much green. A deep breath. A smile. Sounds of love and laughter.

This is what winning looks like. This is what you're fighting for. This is what gets you and your team out of bed every morning to face the hard work that being an activist demands. And this is what is going to motivate others to join you.

Now that we've truly envisioned the world we want, it's time to get practical so we can start making parts of that dream a reality.

HOW DO WE GO FROM THE UTOPIC TO THE PRACTICAL?

Once we have a clear picture of our ideal world, we need just as clear an understanding of the context and audiences of the world we live in today. Next we'll explore the political, demographic, and cultural terrain of our campaign. We'll also research our audiences so we can best identify what we hope for them to think, feel, and do to move the campaign forward.

TOP THREE CATALYSTS FOR CREATIVE CAMPAIGNS

At the Center for Artistic Activism, we've led hundreds of workshops around the world with organizations large and small. We've noticed that the **following three catalysts are critical to a successful campaign**:

- **Clear, specific, and ambitious objectives** so you and your team know exactly what you're aiming for;
- **A detailed and in-depth understanding of your audiences and their cultures** so you can meet them where they are; and
- **Investment in creativity, collaboration, experimentation, and innovation** so your campaign can save resources and be more successful in the long run.

When these three main catalysts are missing, campaigns get bogged down and make less progress.

The rest of this section will help you avoid common pitfalls as you move from your utopian vision to a practical plan.

Remember: **all of this is creative**. Dreaming of that utopian world may seem more obviously creative. But choosing and refining your objectives, visualizing and researching your audience, developing tactics—the entire process of planning your campaign—is creative, too. It's not just an administrative exercise. **The more creativity you invest in these steps, the more likely you'll be to hit upon an innovation or discover a method that will get outstanding results.**



THE ELEMENTS OF A CREATIVE CAMPAIGN

Campaigns are made up of **goals**, **strategies**, **objectives**, and **tactics**. You may have seen these terms before, but we've found they're not often well-defined and that they can be used differently within each organization. Here's how the Center for Artistic Activism defines these terms and how we'll use them throughout this toolkit.

The GOAL is our ultimate destination. This is where we want to end after our long campaign journey. This is a big win we hope to achieve. It may take years, or we may never reach this destination. But having that point on the horizon orients us throughout the process.

STRATEGY is "the way." Once we know where we're going, we can decide the way we'll go about getting there. There are many activist strategies to employ: legal, electoral, educational, mass mobilization, or a creative strategy that employs artistic approaches and cultural resources. Strategies can also be contextual and situational—we may want to consider what strategy will cost the least money, take the least time, reach the most people, etc. Strategies don't tell us where we are going, but they give us the shape of the journey.

OBJECTIVES are demonstrable, measurable milestones along this strategic path to our goal. They are used to define, in the shorter term, an outcome we're working toward—where we want to go and what we want to happen once we're there. They also allow us to measure our progress. As we meet each objective, one milestone leads to the next and we are brought closer and closer to our goal.

TACTICS are the steps leading toward our objective. Within our campaigns they are the individual actions we deploy: the interventions we stage and the pieces we create for people to see, hear, and experience.

Objectives are the outcome. Tactics are the actions that make the outcome happen.

TWO COMMON CONFUSIONS:

***Tactic* or *objective*?**

We've found that people frequently confuse tactics and objectives. A simple way to differentiate them is to think of **objectives** as outcomes or **what happens**, and to think of **tactics** as **actions that make it happen**.

Tactics* are *activism

When people encounter tactics in their everyday lives — a mural depicting the victims of police brutality, a street protest against corruption — it may seem to be the totality of what activism is. But **tactics are only important insofar as they move us closer to the outcomes we desire**. For tactics to be meaningful, purposeful, and effective, they need to be connected to objectives.

EXERCISE

GETTING STARTED WITH OBJECTIVES

5–10 MIN

The most fundamental yet *overlooked* tool for a campaign is having clearly defined objectives and writing them down. These objectives help clarify the scope of work for both yourself and others, and they can guide you through the difficult decisions that inevitably arise along the way.

Unfortunately, **too often we meet with groups who can tell us the topic they're working on but not what they're trying to get done in clear and specific terms**.

Let's change that by getting some objectives on paper.

Get started by writing one thing you want to get done within the next 3–6 months. Here are some tips:

- Write a declaration of an outcome you plan to make happen. Write it in the past tense, as if it already happened — as if you've already succeeded.
- If it is more than a sentence or two, you can probably break it down into two or more objectives that run simultaneously or in parallel. If that's the case, try to separate it out and for now focus on just one (but of course, keep the others for later).
- Aim for a mix of realistic and ambitious.

Here are some examples:

- We got more people to our meetings.
- We held more events in a bigger geographic area.
- We taught more folks about how our issue is showing up on ballots in the next election.

At this point what we have is probably a bit vague. Let's change that.

STRONG OBJECTIVES ARE SMARTIE OBJECTIVES

High-quality objectives are campaign outcomes that inspire us and our colleagues to move forward. They also help new team members and volunteers understand what we're trying to do and ways they can contribute. And, when at their best, quality objectives inspire creative strategies and open up doors to new possibilities for tactics.

While campaign objectives can appear simple and straightforward, getting to a high-quality objective takes **multiple drafts, focused thinking, questioning, and reflection** even for the most experienced creative campaigner.

To review: objectives are the concrete landmarks on our journey that mark our progress toward our big, dreamy goals. The key is making your objectives concrete in every way possible. For an objective to be a clear declaration of outcome, it needs to be these things:

- **Specific:**
  It identifies a particular thing you want to achieve, change, or impact.
- **Measurable:**
  You'll be able to determine whether you've achieved it or not.
- **Achievable:**
  It's something you can realistically hope to do, while still being ambitious and pushing you and your team to have the most success.
- **Relevant:**
  It makes sense given your overall goal.
- **Time-Bound:**
  It's to be done within a given timeframe and with a specific deadline.
- **Inclusive:**
  It centers those most impacted by the issue and has them participate meaningfully.
- **Equitable:**
  It addresses systemic injustice, inequity, and oppression.

It's a lot to remember and that's why there's a fun acronym for it:

S.M.A.R.T.I.E.

EXERCISE

DRAFT SMARTIE OBJECTIVE

20–30 MIN

Work with your team to build your powerful SMARTIE objective.

1) Fill in the fields below.

Our goal is:	
One of our draft objectives is:	
This objective will have this *specific* impact:	
We will know this objective has been achieved when we see these *measurable* results:	
This objective is *achievable* — and ambitious — because:	
This objective is *relevant* to our goal because:	
We'll achieve this objective in the following *time frame*:	
This objective is explicitly *inclusive* because we:	
We'll make sure the objective is overtly *equitable* by:	

2) Now look back at the objective you wrote down at the start of the exercise. How can you revise your objective to include all the SMARTIE details? Write your improved objective below.

Our updated SMARTIE objective is now this:	

HERE'S HOW OUR EARLIER EXAMPLES MIGHT CHANGE

BEFORE: We got more people to our meetings.
AFTER: 10 new potential volunteers living in districts that have an opportunity to receive opioid settlement funds attended our orientation meeting on the 15th of the month. They left knowing at least four people's names from the group and are confident speaking with district voters about how to secure funds for harm reduction.

BEFORE: We held more events in a bigger geographic area.
AFTER: Our campaign held three events in the month of August, each attended by at least 100 people who reflect the diversity of the neighborhood. We talked with at least 50% of them, and more than 25 signed up to receive more info from us.

BEFORE: We taught more people in our city about how our issue is showing up on ballots in the next election.
AFTER: Over 6 months, we talked to at least 500 potential voters about how reproductive rights will be affected by the next election, and why that is relevant to them. At least 40% told us they are committed to voting in the next election.

Notice the difference in the before and after? The SMARTIE prompts help us strengthen our objectives so we can articulate exactly what we want. That's important because **objectives are powerful**. Strong SMARTIE objectives help your team know exactly what they're trying to accomplish. Great objectives get people excited and get their brains thinking of inventive ways of achieving them. **Vague, incomplete, and out-of-date campaign objectives are one of the most common weak points we encounter when working with organizations**. If people aren't clear on what they're trying to achieve, and how each component they're working on relates to the overall goal, there's little chance of success.

Such a specific, predetermined outcome may at first seem confining. However, artists know that **constraints breed creativity**. When someone knows, for example, exactly how many people need to be reached, in what way, by when, and why, they can think of novel ways of hitting all those clearly defined requirements. It may seem counterintuitive, but **we've seen again and again that an objective that is well defined by the seven SMARTIE criteria is a key factor in enabling creativity and innovation to thrive**.

Once updated, your SMARTIE objective should help you establish highly effective short-term plans through which you can identify and evaluate your success (or failure) and **make adjustments mid-campaign.** For example, say your objective was to register 1,000 voters within three months (of course it would want to be SMARTIEr than that, but for now we can say that's the general gist). If it's been six weeks and you've only registered 150, you can then revise your strategies and tactics to try to hit that target, or perhaps you can update your objective to a lower number to reflect a reality you didn't originally anticipate.

→ If your objective has to do with raising awareness about an issue, make sure to read **From Awareness to Action: Stages of Change** at c4aa.org/kit/change. This quick resource will help you make a much stronger objective focused on moving people to action.

THREE MORE WAYS TO MAKE YOUR OBJECTIVES STRONGER

Your objective isn't going to be perfect on the first try—and that's ok! **Getting great at objectives takes time and lots of iteration.** Remember that it's a creative act—there's no one right answer, and we all get better at it with more practice and with great collaboration.

Check your latest draft against the following and see if you can improve it further:

- **Does your SMARTIE objective seem big, overly complex, and/or something you don't think you can get done in the next 3–6 months?** Consider breaking it into multiple, smaller SMARTIE objectives.
- **Are there tactics or strategies mixed into your objective that you can remove?** For example, let's say your objective is to talk to 500 potential voters about how they can help protect reproductive rights in the next election by tabling at the upcoming Juneteenth parade. You can ask yourself: Do you need to do it by tabling? If you got the same thing done by entering your own float into the parade, would that be ok? If tabling isn't strategic or required: take it out.
- **Is your outcome something you can control?** If your objective depends upon the whims of a powerful person, change it. For example:

  "Governor Moneybags changes position on allocation of opioid settlement fund"

  can become

  "Get 3 meetings with Governor Moneybags about opioid settlement funds"

  or it could turn into

  "Meet with 5 people who can influence Governor Moneybags"

  like her husband, her policy advisors, her mentor, her intern, etc.

Again, getting to a strong objective takes reflection and more than one draft. We developed the following exercise to help you speed up that process and get to a stronger objective in about 15 minutes!

OBJECTIVES HAVE A SHORT SHELF LIFE

Note that we like to call all our campaign objectives "**draft objectives**" because they need regular updating. **Objectives are like a very sharp blade that dulls quickly.** They need maintenance in order to keep working for you. Keep your tools sharp. Plan to revise your objectives on a regular basis — every three weeks on average — for the best results.



EXERCISE:

TALK TO THE GENIE

15 MIN

Refine your SMARTIE objective, make it extra strong, and have a little bit of fun.

Good objectives are genie-proof

We've probably all heard an ancient folktale where the protagonist frees a genie or another supernatural being from a magic lamp. The supernatural being grants three wishes in return. But they interpret the wishes literally, which causes all kinds of problems:

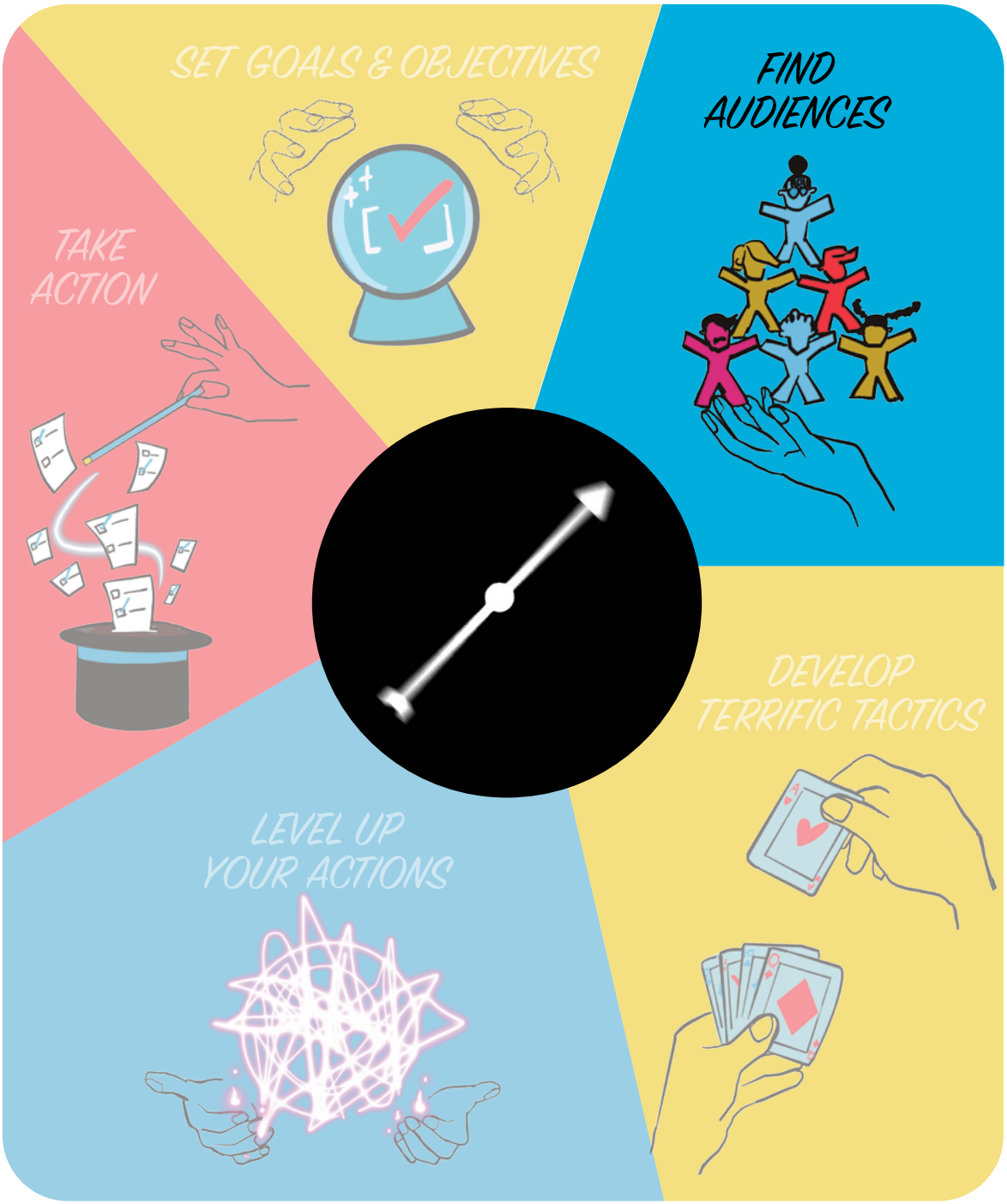
A school kid finds a magic lamp, rubs it, and a genie emerges.
Genie: You have freed me from this lamp, and so I will grant you three wishes.
Kid: Wow! Ok, my first wish is that you make math go away.
Genie: Your wish is granted.
Kid: Really?! Yay! So now I have two wishes left?
Genie: Um, what is a "two"?

Divide your group in two (luckily, for our purposes, math still exists): the wishmakers and the genies. The wishmakers share a draft objective — make a wish — and the genies grant it. The genies are clever and try to undermine the wishmakers while still granting the wish. The wishmakers revise their wish until it is "genie-proof."

For example, the wishmakers might say, "We wish to get 1,000 new volunteers to do community clean-up." The genies could respond, "Alakazam! Your wish is granted. You got 1,000 new volunteers to do community clean-up *in Beverly Hills*." Or "Your wish is granted! You got 1,000 new volunteers to do community clean-up *the day before a huge outdoor festival in your town*." Then the wishmakers get to try again, and keep trying until there's nothing the genie can do to undermine them.

STEP 2

FIND AUDIENCES



Audience is particularly important in campaign planning because social change happens when *people* are moved to change—and your campaign can help move them. But to do this **you need to have a clear idea of whom you want to move and how**. Knowing your audiences means you can employ the particular signs, symbols, and stories that resonate with them, which means you have a better likelihood of creating something with significant impact. This is easiest to do with a clearly defined audience.

But there are so many possible audiences to reach—which one do you pick? This question is best answered with another one: **What audience is most important to your objective**?

EXERCISE:

FIND YOUR AUDIENCE

30 MIN

When planning campaigns for social change, people often do **Power Mapping**. The basics are simple: you map out who has the power to realize your objectives so you can direct your project toward them.

For example, if your aim is to create public pressure about your issue, then those who have the most power to do this might be news reporters or bloggers or even popular celebrities or influencers. If you want to get a law passed, then who has the power to do that? Probably politicians.

But it's not always so simple. While politicians create laws, the people with power over politicians are voters (or rich donors). Similarly, while the news media can spread your message, often these media are beholden to advertisers. This is why it's important to **map out all those who have the power to create the change you want and those who have power over them**. By doing this you can determine who is the most impactful audience to target through your campaign.

Choose a primary audience

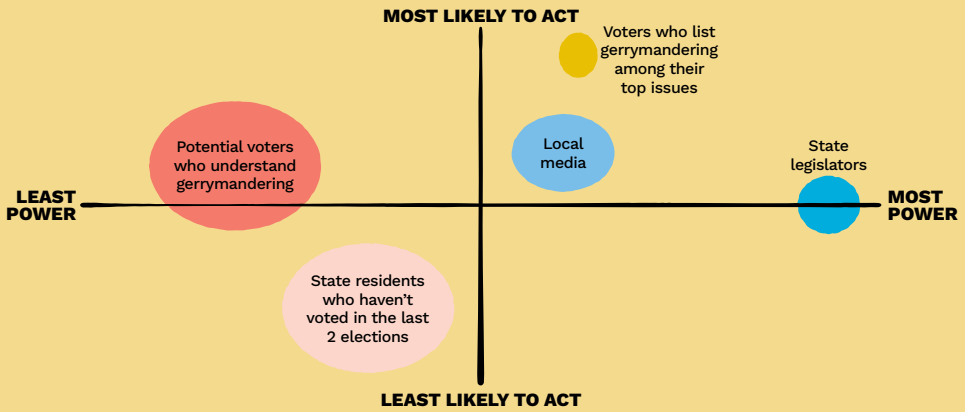
Revisit one of your draft SMARTIE objectives. Then draw a grid like this:



You may want to adjust the language here, but the aim is to put closer to the top the people who you think probably agree with you and are more likely to take action, and put people lower down who are less likely to agree or act.

Next, brainstorm audiences. Think broadly about everyone who is affected by and affects the issue, even tangentially. As activists, this kind of power mapping is probably something you already do: who are the volunteers, children, artists, administrators, business owners, customers, and others involved in intersecting issues?

Draw the audiences on your matrix, each with its own circle that roughly coincides with the relative size of the audience. Sometimes if you're working on a team, it's interesting for people to do this separately and then compare their maps. Unexpected ideas often arise.



Refine your audience

Now look at your map.

Those who have the most power and are most likely to take action may seem like the best first choice for your campaign. But you may want, instead, to work first on an audience that has less direct power over the issue but has interesting potential because they already believe in your cause and need only a few nudges to take action.

The size of your audience matters, too. When audiences are very broad, it means your campaign messages can't be crafted as specifically to them, and the likelihood of moving that broad audience to action decreases. For example, rather than an audience in the hundreds of thousands or millions, a smaller and more specific audience most likely allows you to create a campaign that will really resonate.

THINK FEEL DO

Now that you've identified your primary audience — the audience who's the main focus of your current campaign — imagine what you hope your audience will think, feel, and do when they experience your campaign.

Think: What ideas do I want these people to have and hold about my issue?
Feel: What do I want my audience to feel? Do I want them to be mad? Hopeful? Empowered?
Do: What actions do I want the folks I am targeting to take? What behaviors do I want to change?

→ You can do all this for other audiences you've identified, too, including ones we like to call secondary audiences and unintended audiences. Learn more about them at c4aa.org/kit/audiences.

THINK FEEL DO IN ACTION

Let's say we're working on promoting access to free essential medicines—like insulin. You might define your primary audience as:

> Patients and their families in our city who are informed about the importance of access to medicines but haven't taken action yet.

This narrows what could have been a massive audience by focusing on a smaller geographic area where we might be able to leverage personal connections and their networks to enact change.

We then define what we want this audience to think, feel, and do:

- **I want my audience to THINK:**
  Accessing the health care I need doesn't have to break the bank.
- **I want my audience to FEEL:**
  Energized, determined, engaged, optimistic, connected, supported, interested, and inspired to increase access to essential medicines.
- **I want my audience to DO:**
  Make a plan to talk to a least 5 other people about why this issue is important to their lives and those of their loved ones, and come to a local advocacy group's next strategy meeting.

So now we have clear, concrete thoughts, feelings, and actions we envision for our audience. This will enable us to craft a project that succeeds on all of those levels. We might create an interactive experience that replicates accessing medicines in a city with universal health care. We might offer a health care concierge service to help members of our primary audience navigate their current health needs and get answers to questions in a colorful, fun setting with upbeat, energizing music, and yummy snacks. There are endless possibilities, and now we know our decisions will be guided by what we want our audiences to THINK, FEEL, and DO!



Public health activists rally for fair drug pricing in Barcelona, Spain.

EXERCISE:

THINK FEEL DO

5-10 MIN

Now that you've defined your primary audience, write out what you want them to think, feel, and do.

- What do you want your primary audience to **THINK**?
- What do you want your primary audience to **FEEL**?
- What do you want your primary audience to **DO**?

→ If you're having a hard time figuring out what you want your audience to do, read **From Awareness to Action: Stages of Change** at c4aa.org/kit/change.

What follows are more exercises we've found helpful for identifying audiences and knowing how to communicate æffectively with them. The first exercise focuses on creating an imaginary person—an "**audience persona**"—that serves as a stand-in for the type of person you'd like to reach. The next helps you **connect that audience to your objective**. The third is an excellent and fun way for your team to look at the **popular culture** you're operating within, and the fourth exercise steps back and **"maps" the social context of your audience** so that we have a better idea of who they are, where they're coming from, and how best to speak to them and move them to action.

→ If you're planning to lead a meeting with your team and not sure they'll be immediately ready to jump into this kind of creative work together, we have a few ways to jumpstart your team's creativity: the **Uncovering Creativity** and **Creativity From Combination** exercises at c4aa.org/kit/creativity.

EXERCISE:

AUDIENCE PERSONAS

20-30 MIN

This exercise will help you **develop a personalized image or picture of whom you want to reach, which will help you keep your ideas grounded in and inspired by those audiences**.

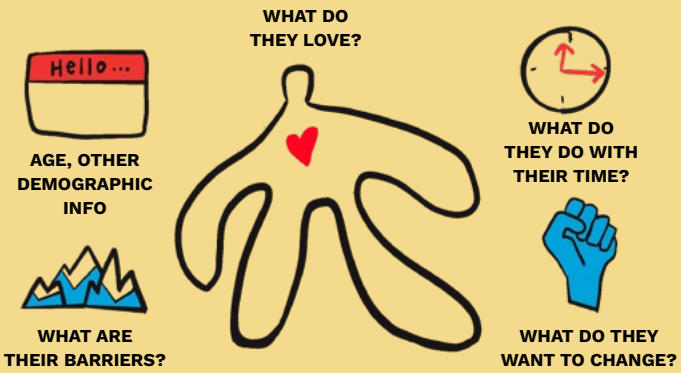
1. Review the **primary audience** you identified.
2. Visualize that primary audience in your mind. Imagine their faces, what they are wearing, things they might be doing today. Now make that image even more specific by giving this person **a name, an age, and other demographic characteristics**. Instead of ranges like 18-34 years old, push yourself to define this person: *Clara, 61, a first-generation Jamaican immigrant and retired mechanical engineer who lives in the X neighborhood of X town*. If it helps, you can base your persona on one person or a collection of people you know.

3. Write down two or three things in response to each of the following:

- **a. What do they do with their time** (work life, creative life, social life)? *This is important because it's what you'll be competing against for their attention and energy.*
- **b. What do they love?** What do they go out of their way to do? What lights up their enthusiasm? *Understanding what truly excites and interests them is crucial for finding authentic connections and enables you to make your work more appealing and engaging.*
- **c. What do they struggle with?** What prevents them from being their fullest selves? What are their barriers to joining your cause? *This is vital to know because you'll need to overcome them in your campaign*.
- **d. What are some things they already want to change in the world?** *This is helpful because almost any desire for change can be linked to other social issues. By aligning your message with their existing concerns, you can build a more compelling case for action.*

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4. Draw a quick portrait of your persona where they are surrounded by the occupations, loves, struggles, and desire for change you listed above.



Discuss these personas in your group and make any additions and changes. You might also want to consider which persona(s) are most relevant for achieving your objective. Later, when you're revising your objectives and developing your tactics, check in with your personas. Let's say you have a persona you name Jeanine. What would Jeanine think about the event you're planning? Would she approach your action on the street — or walk the opposite way? Would your messaging appeal to Jeanine or turn her off? With these insights, adjust your plans to make sure you're being strategic in helping this audience think, feel, and do what you've identified.

Now that you have a persona, it's time to think more specifically about them in relation to your objective and why they may, or may not, want to take the action you're trying to get them to do.

EXERCISE:

COST-BENEFIT ANALYSIS

30 MIN

For those of us working on a campaign, the reason for taking action is obvious and the act itself is one already done, often multiple times. **We're in a different place than our audiences, which can make it hard to understand why any reasonable person would be hesitant or refuse to join us**.

For example, as an advocate it may be hard to understand why people don't engage in any number of activities: voting, calling their representatives, volunteering for causes they care about, speaking up against injustice, etc.

This exercise gives insights into audiences that are in a different relationship to our issue than we are, so we can make effective changes, design better actions, speak, and be heard.

In the box to the right, write down the following, in this order:

1. One of your **SMARTIE objectives**
2. The name of your **audience persona**
3. The **desired behavior**: what you want your audience to do. Do you want them to sign a petition? Volunteer at your next event? Take part in an advocacy action? Write this behavior down.
4. Their **current behavior**: what are they doing now that's different from the above? Managing their everyday life? Taking care of their kids? Hitting the local bars and nightclubs?
5. List at least three perceived **benefits and costs** to your audience in performing the **desired behavior**. Note that **for both costs and benefits, these are *perceived*** — they might not actually be "true" according to us. They're simply perceptions our audience may have. Perceived benefits could be the feeling of making a difference and meeting amazing new people (as in,

your team!). Perceived costs could be financial — the cost of transportation to an event — and also broader: four hours lost on a weekend, time spent that could be given to other obligations, a risk to reputation or identity, or even just getting stuck doing something new — which might be awful.

6. List at least three **benefits and costs** your audience persona perceives for their **current behavior**.

   Consider anything a person might perceive as something positive from continuing their life as is, like: spending time with loved ones, staying organized and on top of things, seeing their kids smile, getting to relax and release. Then consider what a person is missing out on by not doing what you want them to do: not making a difference, sticking to a potentially boring routine, not living up to their ideals, etc.

1) Objective:		
2) Audience:		
	3) Desired Behavior:	**4) Current Behavior:**
Benefits	**5)** • • •	**6)** • • •
Costs	**5)** • • •	**6)** • • •

In your campaign, now you can think about ways to highlight the benefits of the desired behavior and costs of the current behavior and/or minimize (without naively ignoring) the benefits of the current behavior and the costs of the desired behavior.

Here's an example based on a workshop we led with reproductive justice activists in California:

Objective: 500 people attend our next event and leave committed to participating in the movement overall.

Audience: Folks who are aware of the pro-choice movement but are not yet engaged/committed regularly. They care (we're not changing hearts and minds) but need to be moved to mobilize.

	Current Behavior: Attend one event and NEVER COME BACK	**Desired Behavior:** "SEE YOU EVERY TIME!"
Benefits	• Calendar is open! • Wallow in victimhood and outrage • Save time and energy • No responsibility • Can't fail!	• Outlet for anxiety • Sleep better — sense of accomplishment • It gets easier when it becomes routine • We're cool, fun, nice people • Living your values • Fun swag • Status — feels good to be part of a movement • Learning new skills • Helping future generations
Costs	• They lose their rights • Living inauthentically • FOMO/miss out on community • Less informed — they think the issue is worse than it is • Never see details or victories • Guilt	• Planning/social conflicts — losing time with family & friends • Risk of overwork and burnout • Accountable — there are people you could let down • The work is for the long haul and won't provide instant gratification • Risked relationships • Perceived safety risk • Scrutiny of others • Walking the walk is harder

In order to help you and your team tap into the desires and barriers of your target audience, you may need to get out and explore more. The following work on pop culture is especially fun and useful work for a team to do together.



Climate change activists and artists engage young people through art and fashion outside Johannesburg, South Africa.

FIND INSPIRATION FROM POP CULTURE

Pop culture has a lot to teach us about successful creative campaigns. Reality dating shows, tabloid magazines, telenovelas, Bollywood movies, football matches, K-pop songs, video games, and that commercial you can't get out of your head can all help you generate effective campaign ideas.

Are we encouraging you to watch reality TV shows instead of doing your job?

Really, we're saying watching reality TV is part of your job. Popular culture has been thoroughly tested and proven: people like it. Of course, a lot of it celebrates the rich and the privileged, the sensational and the violent; it functions to support capitalism; and so on. But we can know that and set it aside because we can't culturally isolate ourselves from the populations we hope to persuade. **If we take a little time to understand pop culture and the reasons our audiences are drawn to it, we can strengthen our ability to reach them**.

What are your potential audiences doing when they're not showing up at your action? Probably staying at home watching the latest season of that show you wish you could be watching yourself. **Pop culture is our competition. But the good news is it's also a creative resource to use and subvert**.

At the heart of popular culture—way below the commercialism and spectacle on the surface—hide popular dreams. For instance, celebrity culture, at its heart, taps into the everyday desire to be seen and recognized in a world where most of us are unnoticed and unrecognized. Video games and superhero movies tap into the longing for heroic action and agency in a world that desperately needs saving but offers people few meaningful opportunities toward that end.

You can channel these same desires into your campaigns. You can run meetings where everyone feels seen and has a chance to be heard. You can stage a thrilling (as opposed to routine and/or boring) intervention that gives people agency and moments of heroism. And so much more.

The following exercise gives you a taste of the culture your audience is engaging in. It's also useful to get an even deeper understanding of the cultural and creative terrain for your audience and your own team so you can best make use of and fit in to the wider trends and skills at your fingertips.



Voting activists and C4AA team members go on a pop culture inspiration mission to a minor league baseball game. Credit: Unstoppable Voters Fellowship Retreat, Virginia Beach, VA, 2023.

EXERCISE:

FROM POP CULTURE TO CREATIVE CAMPAIGNS

A FUN EVENING WITH FRIENDS

Work together to understand the desires that pop culture taps into and how you can embed them in your campaign.

- **Think of the people you want your campaign to attract and engage. What do they do for fun?** Do they go to baseball games, dance clubs, climbing gyms? Do they watch telenovelas, line dance to country music, binge British comedies? Do some research and identify a few key activities they do for fun.
- **Go on a field trip**. Visit a place they go, watch a show they watch, play the sport they play, immerse yourself in the culture they enjoy. As you enjoy the experience yourself, also **view it with the eyes of an anthropologist** studying this fascinating but foreign culture (even if it's not foreign to you). Watch what people are doing. Pay attention to the content and style. Take notes. And remember: don't just stand on the sidelines. Participate and have fun with it!
- Later that day or the next morning, look through your notes. Your audience could be doing so many other things with their time, but they're not. This activity is especially rewarding for them in some way. Ask yourself, **what needs and desires is this pop culture fulfilling for your audience?** Take a few minutes and make a list. For example, the slow pace of attending a live baseball game allows for social conversation and connection. Or a dance course provides participants with various physical challenges and helps them build skills to meet them.
- **What are some specific ways that you could address these desires through your campaign?** Take a few minutes and brainstorm at least five ways you could offer people an experience that gives them a feeling similar to one they get through pop culture.

Dig deep. **The point is not to replicate popular culture, but to learn from it.** Just because superheroes wear tights, and people like superheroes, doesn't mean you should wear underpants over leggings at your next action (though if that's what makes you happy, by all means). You want to tap into underlying human needs and desires this pop culture phenomenon fulfills.

EXERCISE:

GET TO KNOW YOUR CULTURAL TERRAIN

5-10 MIN

All campaigns occur within a cultural context, and we need to account for the context within which we are working if we hope to be successful. What's exciting is that the landscape is often more open and expansive than we could imagine.

Grab a few big pieces of paper and invite your team and collaborators to brainstorm on these questions:

Cultural context

What signs, symbols, stories, and media are part of the terrain that your target audiences are operating within?

- What sorts of signs and symbols resonate with the population?
- What types of stories do people tell themselves? What myths do they believe? What jokes do they like?
- What artistic representations and expressions, languages, patterns, and rituals of everyday life do people identify with?
- What popular forms of entertainment do people enjoy? Are there alternative forms of culture that people create?
- What media do people rely upon for information?

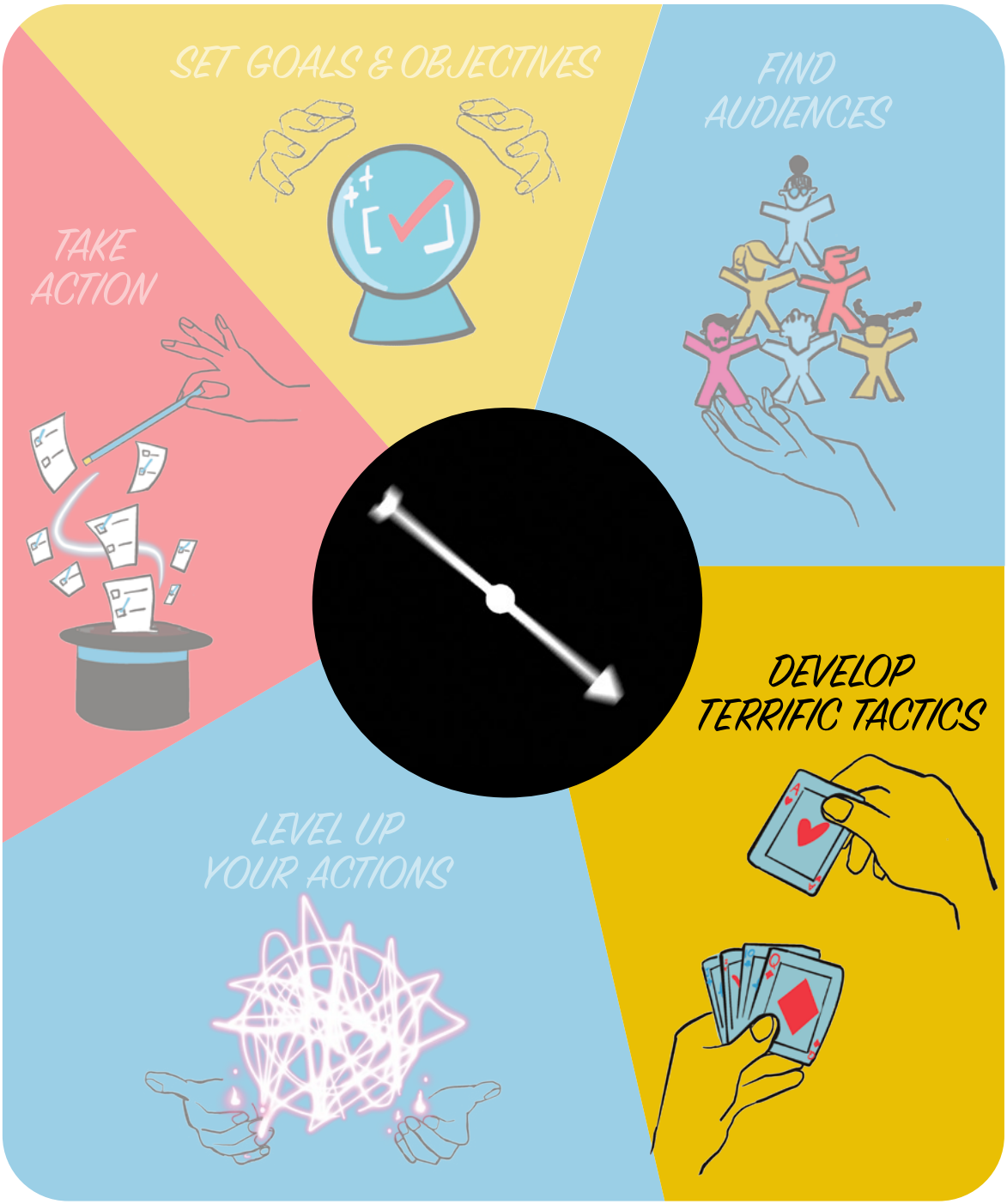
Creative resources

- What creative resources and skills does your team have?
- What creative individuals do you know?
- What arts organizations, social justice institutions, or other groups might lend a hand?
- Who do you know in the media who might be sympathetic and willing to work with you?

Review your lists together. **We've seen lightbulbs go off for groups when they do this**. They realize they have an opera singer on their team, or an in at a radio station, or an unexpected way to reach an audience. This kind of information is very useful as we begin to develop ideas for tactics.

STEP 3:

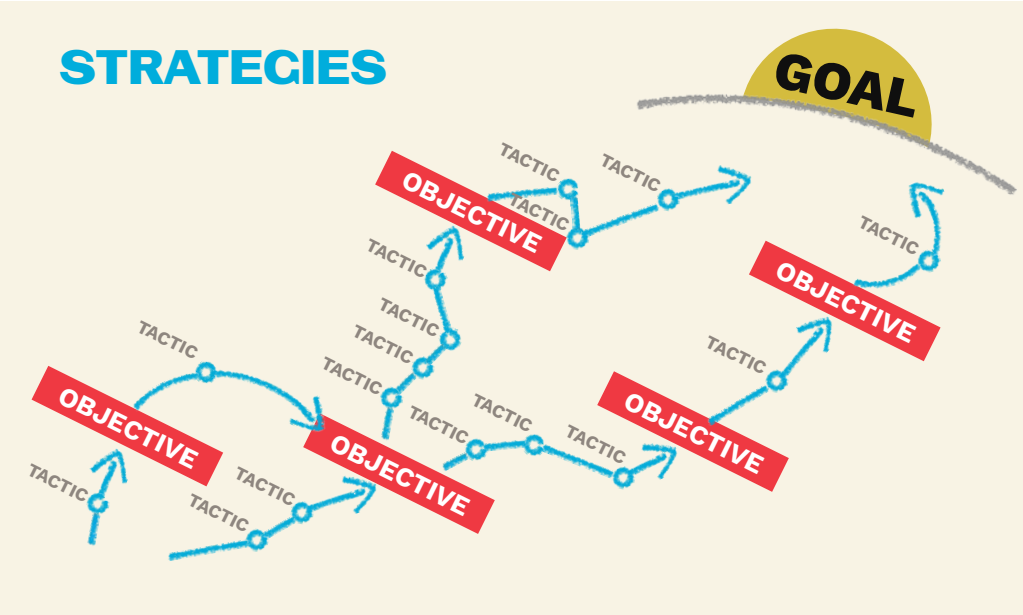
DEVELOP TERRIFIC TACTICS



You've envisioned your big **goals** and crafted really specific **objectives** to get you towards them. You have defined your **audiences** and explored the **cultural terrain** you're operating in. **Now you're ready to invent the individual tactics**, or actions, that'll help you accomplish your objectives.

WHAT ARE TACTICS?

Tactics are the basic unit of activism. They're the actions and interventions we stage and the pieces we create for people to see, hear, experience—and that move them to take action. Through our tactics, we move closer to achieving our objectives.



An important note about tactics: there's no one-size-fits-all "good tactic." Developing great tactics means carefully considering the **context** in which they will exist, how they **engage** your audience(s) and **make sense** to them, and whether they **challenge expectations** enough to be noticeable and memorable.

GETTING TO TERRIFIC TACTICS

How do we start the process of coming up with good tactics that fit the context of our campaign? **The following exercise is one of our most useful.** It will help you generate dozens of tactic ideas very quickly. Not all of them will be good, and that's ok! The exercise is an extremely helpful starting place in finding innovative tactics that will move you forward in your campaign.

EXERCISE:

MAKING THE IMPOSSIBLE POSSIBLE

20 MIN

1. **Choose one of your SMARTIE objectives**. Make sure your audience and outcome are clear. (See Steps 1 and 2 if you haven't defined these yet.)

2. Get a timer ready and plan to **brainstorm 10 tactic ideas in 10 minutes** (yes — that comes down to one per minute). Remember, your tactics are actions (not outcomes) that help you achieve the objective.

   IMPORTANT: The first seven tactics you write down *must* be impossible. Meaning you don't have the budget, number of volunteers, or time to pull it off. Beyond that, they could be wildly unpopular or unethical, break the laws of physics, cost billions. They could require 10,000 sandwiches, alien technology, singing dragons (or all three). **The more weird, outlandish, and fun, the better!** These tactics should not magically solve the problem (e.g., not "Glenda the Good Witch waves her wand and our objective is achieved") but should involve impossible actions that move your campaign forward to victory — "Glenda takes your city council on a mind-expanding tour of the enchanting public housing within the Emerald City of Oz."

   After you come up with the seven impossible ideas, you can come up with three possible ones.

   Don't overthink it — just get your ideas written down. And give yourself a bonus point for every extra idea you can write down after the tenth.

3. At the end of your 10 minutes, **review your ideas**. If you divided into groups, share with each other.

4. Then, give yourself a few minutes to **make the impossible possible**. Pick one impossible idea you're excited about. What are ways you can make it possible? Can you keep the essence and do it on a smaller scale? Temporarily? Using costumes, models, or props? Or within the context of a video? Did your impossible tactic involve carrying people to the polls on those singing dragons we mentioned? Make it possible with a dragon-painted bus and a karaoke machine!

5. Repeat this with a few more of your "impossible" ideas to generate at least 5–10 more possible ideas — and **watch the possibilities for your campaign expand**.

In a short time you generated 15 – 20 ideas for tactics. Don't worry — they're not all supposed to be winners, or even feasible. But when there's at least one with potential that excites you, then you've made an important step forward.

WE WANT QUANTITY OVER QUALITY

No, that's not a mix-up. **In this phase, generating a large quantity of ideas is far more important than coming up with quality ideas**.

In the last exercise you came up with 15-20 ideas. Why come up with so many? Because **we get to a few good ideas through developing a wealth of ideas** — "good" ideas and "bad" ideas and everything in between. **Allow yourself to let go of the pressure to create good ideas and instead push yourself to produce the largest number of ideas you can**.

A great example of this is in filmmaking. Whether you've worked on a film shoot or not, you've seen a clapboard fill the screen and someone shout, "Take two!" — or possibly "Take twenty-eight!" — before the clapboard stick snaps shut. Editors then use these shots, selecting from hundreds of hours of "raw footage" to create the final 90 to 120 minutes we see on the screen. This difference in raw footage and the final edit is called the "shooting ratio." A major film may have a 30:1 shooting ratio — they shoot 30 hours to get one good hour. A documentary may have closer to a 100:1 shooting ratio. But it can vary greatly. *Mad Max: Fury Road*, which won 10 Academy Awards including best picture and best director, had a shooting ratio of 245:1.

Have your team aspire to a 40:1 ratio. With 40 ideas on the table, you have more to select from, combine, and work with, significantly increasing your odds of discovering innovative and effective elements for your campaign.

→ To learn more about the value of multiple tactics, head to **More Tactics! Make Your Bets** at c4aa.org/kit/moretactics.

You might be wondering: **why does this impossible-possible brainstorming method work**? It works because:

- Starting with the impossible opens up options that would otherwise be shut down by practical thinking, and
- Having to generate so many ideas in a short time means less overthinking and self-editing, and more tapping into the unconscious and unexpected.

With these few exercises and a bit of time, you've now sketched a long list of exceptionally inventive tactics: some weird, some winners, some unworkable. Next we figure out which ones to choose and if they're ready to use. If your team is struggling to decide, **in this step we have lots of ways to help**. Look through and **see what might be most useful for your team**. Use some, or all, to strengthen your ideas and significantly enhance your chances of success.

EXERCISE:

THE FIRST PASS

15–20 MIN

Start the process of sorting through your ideas and making them even stronger.

First, spend a few minutes just playing around with your tactics and see if you can push them. Ask the group questions like, "What would you do if we had twice the budget? Or if we could do this every day for a month?" Take those ideas and see if any of them are feasible or could be adapted given the resources you have.

Then work together to do the following:

- **Optimize for Objectives**
  Remember your goals and objectives — why you're doing this to begin with. **Which tactic will get you closest to achieving that outcome?** Which tactic is most likely to lead to the "Think Feel Do" you hoped for from your audience? (Look back at Step 2 if you need a refresher on "Think Feel Do.") You could have a wonderfully innovative idea with the potential to be easy, attention-getting, impressive, and fun — but **if it's not leading you to directly achieve one of your concrete objectives, it's leading you astray**. Remove tactics that get your plans off track.
- **Find Team Enthusiasm**
  Consider your team's excitement and passion. You're the ones working on it, after all! **If there are several tactics that could achieve your objective, lean towards ones you and your team have enthusiasm for** as that can fuel the execution and success of the campaign. Set aside ones that no one wants to take on.

- **Center Audience Connection**
  Think about your target audience's interests and preferences: their hopes, dreams, desires, and fears, the culture they exist within, and the popular culture they enjoy. **Look for tactics that can resonate with and appeal to them**, creating strong connection and engagement.
- **Embrace Surprise**
  Seek out tactics that surprise and captivate. Actions that are unexpectedly personal, generous, emotional, or just use unusual approaches are more likely to **capture attention, spur engagement, and increase mobilization**.

ASK YOUR PERSONA

As you're choosing your tactics, check back in with your persona and their perceived costs and benefits to engaging with you (Step 2). **You want your tactics to emphasize the benefits of the desired behavior and minimize the costs.**

For example, if we've thought that convenience and transportation might be barriers for our audience, our tactics might literally make voting more convenient by working to extend voting hours, drive people to the polls, increase locations — or all of the above.

By considering these four central points, you can **streamline your decision-making process and narrow down tactics that will lead to a successful campaign**. However, you'll likely be left with more than enough possibilities and unsure about which to pursue, or you may have varying perspectives within your team about which ideas to choose.

CONSIDER MULTIPLE TACTICS

Adding more tactics might seem overwhelming at first, but it doesn't need to be. **There are several advantages to working on multiple tactics at once.** Developing more than one idea helps everyone be more creative. It creates opportunities to synthesize and combine ideas to make them stronger. And in the most practical sense, **it's easier and more effective to develop a handful of ideas quickly, see how they perform, and then "double down" on the winners — rather than to bet everything on one singular, seemingly perfect idea from the beginning**.

Other benefits: **Decisions don't get bogged down by trying to get everyone to agree on a single path forward**. A mix of tactics also lets us choose one tactic that's **more creative** and ambitious, one that's more **cautiously practical** but likely to succeed, and a "**moonshot**" idea that has low odds of success but has the potential to propel your campaign forward like nothing else.

EXERCISE:

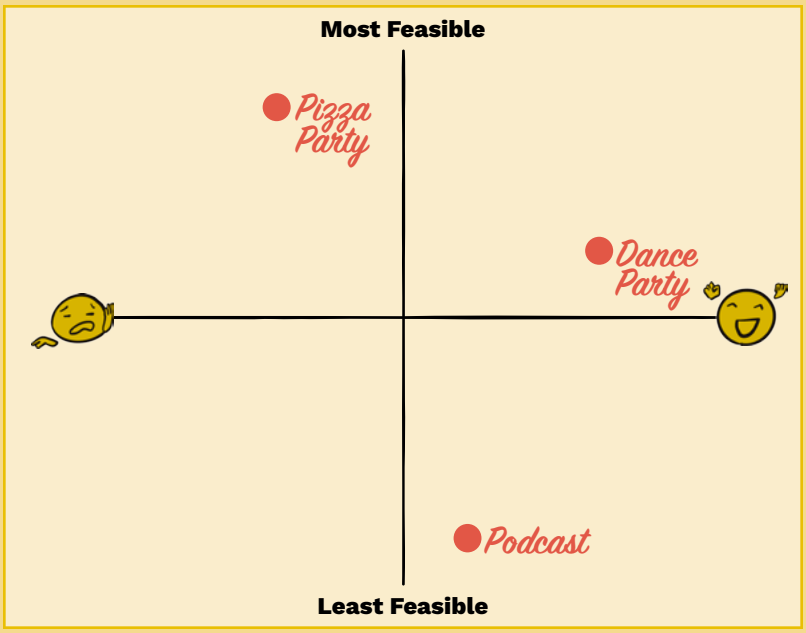
FUN WAYS TO CHOOSE TACTICS

15–60 MIN

There are lots of ways to evaluate and choose tactics, and it's especially useful to find ones that are fun and playful for your team. A few of our favorites include:

Sorting Tactic Ideas Visually

Use a matrix or other visual so your team can evaluate ideas against two different values. On each axis, put something that's important to your team — in the example below, that's how exciting an action is and how feasible it is. Your team can come up with your own values for the two axes. Then you can plot the different tactic ideas on the grid, finding where they fall across the two values. For example, the pizza party is very feasible but only moderately exciting; the dance party is very exciting but only moderately feasible. Then together your team can evaluate which it makes sense to try (if not both).



→ More details and a step-by-step guide to using a matrix like this to choose tactics are at c4aa.org/kit/matrix.

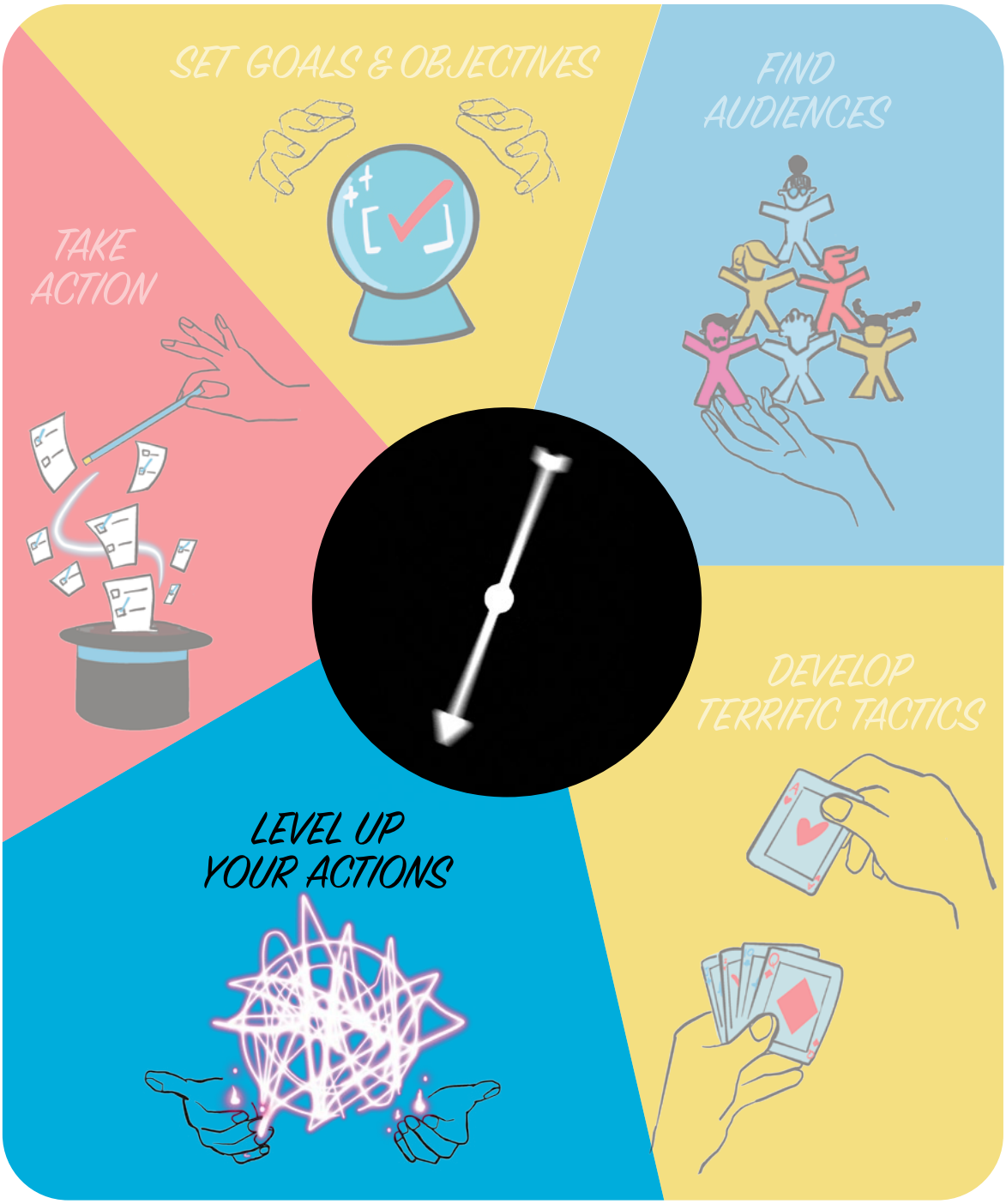
Acting It Out

It never fails to amaze us **how much you can learn by taking a little time to act out an action idea**. Seeing an action staged, even in a very rough form, gives insights you can use to evaluate actions and know whether they need more development or if they're ready to go forward. This can be done in as little as half an hour, and **it requires no performance skills**. You can decide how you want to do this with your team.

→ More about ways to act out your actions as a method to choose and refine tactics is at **Putting the "Act" in Tactic** at c4aa.org/kit/acting.

STEP 4:

LEVEL UP YOUR ACTIONS



We've worked with thousands of activists around the world as they develop campaigns and actions. Over and over, we've seen the most successful actions do the following:

- Center Celebration, Hope, and Joy
- Use Mystery, Whimsy, and Surprise
- Create Irresistible Imagery
- Make it Personal
- Pursue Risk and Innovation
- Invite Meaningful Participation and Interaction

CENTER CELEBRATION, HOPE, AND JOY

It's important to celebrate victories, illuminate the paths where hope lies, and embrace the joy of realizing a better world. **Work good feelings into everything**.



A Philadelphia student is cheered on by his classmates after voting for the first time. Credit: "Teens March on the Ballot Box," Philadelphia, PA, October 2022. Photo by Cain Images.

WHAT YOU CAN DO

Ask yourself: *How can we make our action more joyful, welcoming, celebratory, and/or hopeful?*

USE MYSTERY, WHIMSY, AND SURPRISE

If your audience can immediately classify your action as "a political thing," they're likely to dismiss it without much thought. By using a bit of mystery and surprise, we create a brief window where viewers are compelled to reflect as they try to make sense of what's happening. Within that window is an opportunity to present new ideas, new perspectives and ways of understanding, challenges to conventional beliefs, or novel solutions to complex problems.

Tap into curiosity with the unexpected. Does someone expect to see a giant purple whale in the sky at the beach? Or a grand fair about access to medicines? Within these odd moments you can capture people's attention, make a connection, and move folks to action.



WHYlie the Whale wows potential voters outside of Atlanta, Georgia.

WHAT YOU CAN DO

Ask yourself: *How can we make this more strange or unexpected?*

→ We can't state enough how effective the element of surprise is. For more ways to tap into it, including an exercise to help you find opportunities to embed surprise in your tactic, see **SURPRISE!** at c4aa.org/kit/surprise.

CREATE IRRESISTIBLE IMAGERY

For a moment, **set aside the images in your mind of what a campaign event, a protest, or a political action looks like**—tabling, hanging banners, lofting protest signs in the air—*all of it*. What are fabulous, large-scale ways you can take up space? How can you turn your message into a visual metaphor that communicates what you want to say? Groups we've worked with have done this with everything including life-size whale kites, giant eyes on city trees, hundreds of rubber duckies, living statues, and opera-worthy costuming.

Embrace spectacle. Imagine you're creating a photograph that will appear on the front page of a newspaper, on television news, and all over social media—because when you're successful, it will. Imagine a scene that is unforgettable, stops passersby in their tracks, and compels them to snap photos and immediately share the moment with others. The right spectacle can ignite curiosity and spread your message far and wide, capturing the attention of not just individuals but entire communities. Dare to be bold; let your visuals speak louder than words.

WHAT YOU CAN DO

Ask yourself: *Can we create an image or moment or spectacle that is irresistible?*



Activists and artists in London, England, create a visually-engaging parade to advocate for free global access to COVID vaccines.

MAKE IT PERSONAL

Nobody wants to be treated like they're a number—just one among thousands needed for someone else's victory. **One-on-one connections, personal attention, and tailored campaigns can help with these challenges and more**. Thinking about specific audiences and how to make a genuine connection with them will enrich your campaign.

Write down a few ways you can make your campaign more personal or human-centered. Is there some local or cultural anchor you can include: food, music, rituals? How can you help people feel comfortable engaging in deep conversation about why your issue matters? Can you create a variety of tailored approaches for your team to select from instead of a one-size-fits-all script? How can you help people feel like it's them you're speaking to rather than making a broadcast to a demographic? Is there a way their thoughts and beliefs can, in some way, impact the direction and outcome of your event? By infusing your campaign with these kinds of elements, you establish a deeper connection with people, letting them know they are seen, heard, and valued.



Artists and activists create personal, public interventions in Queens, New York to advocate for immigrant rights.

PURSUE RISK AND INNOVATION

Risk and reward are closely linked. However, we hear from lots of groups, especially those working under oppressive regimes, that some **creative campaign and tactic ideas get stopped in their tracks because of fears around the risks involved**. All of us may have a tendency to fall back to more traditional and well-worn tactics out of fear of trying something unknown—whether because we're afraid of oppression or looking silly. But it's when we pursue opportunities to push the boundaries that we can find the most surprising and rewarding success.



Public health activists and artists collaborate on creative action ideas in a C4AA workshop in Nairobi, Kenya.

WHAT YOU CAN DO

- **Make a Risk Manifesto:** Talk amongst your team and wider organization about how, collectively, you want to approach risk and reward.
- **Conduct Experiments:** Agree to do two small experiments in the next three months that nudge the boundaries of what is considered risky.
- **Examine the Boundary-Pushers:** Look to colleagues, artists, activists, and other cultural agents who are pushing the boundaries and navigating risk successfully.

→ If a fear of risk-taking tends to limit your team's creativity, read more about ways to address this challenge at **Is It Risky Enough?** at c4aa.org/kit/risk.

INVITE MEANINGFUL PARTICIPATION AND INTERACTION

Engaging actions successfully capture our audience's attention, communicate our goals, get people to interact and respond, create meaningful and memorable experiences that resonate, and ultimately win participants' support. Ideally, we hope to achieve a **two-way relationship** where the audience takes part in the experience rather than just observing. Ways your audience could participate during your action might include playing a game, sitting down to talk with you, taking photos of the action, or contributing their thoughts in writing or in some other way.



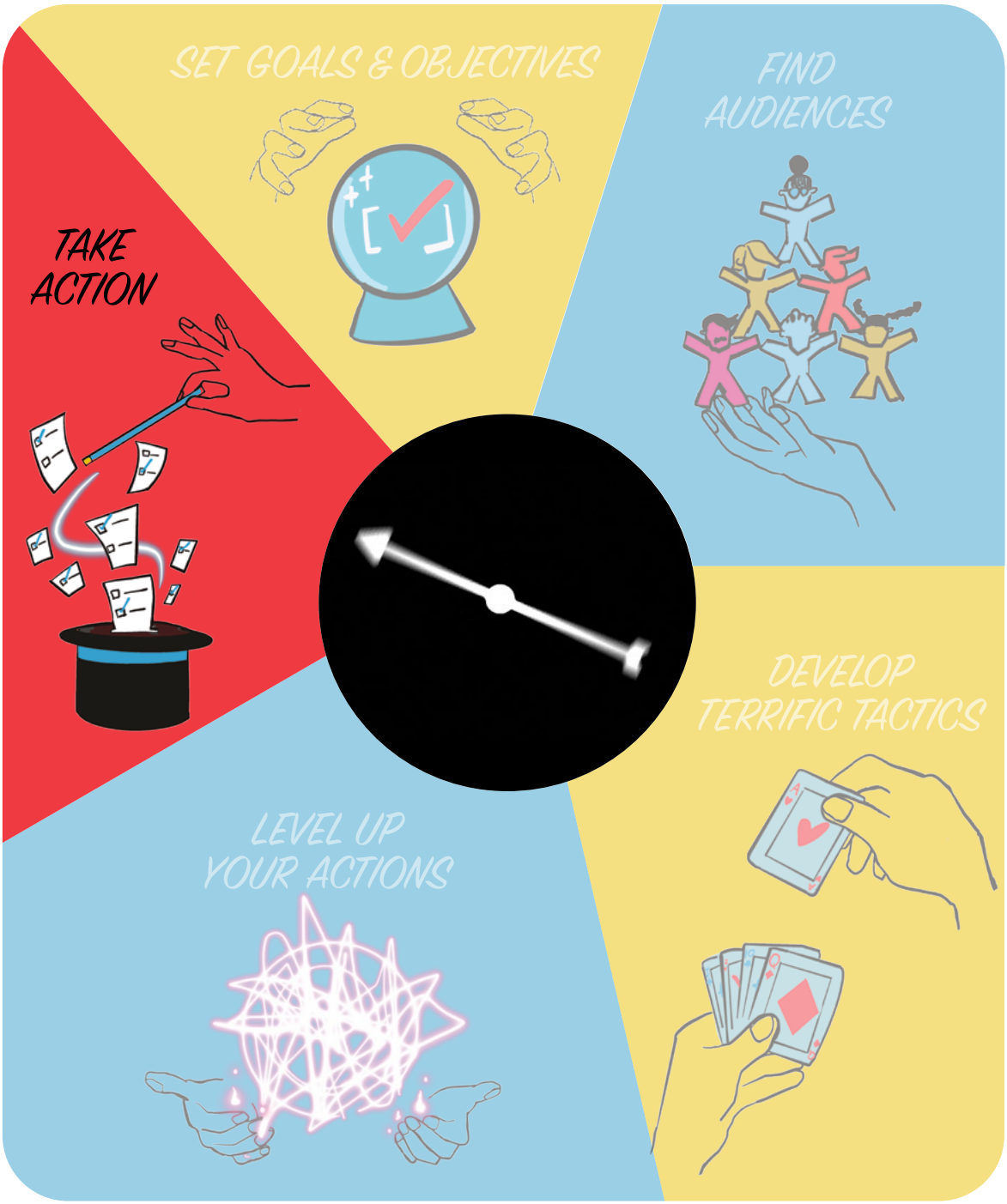
Texans participate in an interactive ritual to cast spells, cast ballots, and cast the demons out of the state capitol. Credit: "Texorcism" by Democrasexy, Austin, TX, 2022. Photos by Nicki Lemon.

→ To help you create a spectacle that's interactive, it's helpful to think of your action as a performance and to assign roles accordingly. For more on those roles and how they can help keep an action on track, see **Actions are Performances: Cast Your Characters** at c4aa.org/kit/cast.

WHAT YOU CAN DO

Ask yourself: *How can we make this more interactive and participatory?* Make sure your tactics include at least one clear thing you're asking your audience to DO while they're there — and very importantly, after they leave.

STEP 5:
TAKE ACTION



Taking action goes hand in hand with observing, reflecting, and assessing. As we enact the plan, we're also keeping an eye on how it's working, checking against our our aims and intentions. We take note of what's exceeding our expectations, what's falling short, and what we never accounted for within the plan. This way we can rework in real time, inventing new ways to adapt to what's happening, making adjustments with each iteration to improve the campaign as it's running. Working iteratively allows you to correct for mistakes, fine-tune your approach, and increase impact.

PROTOTYPE. PROTOTYPE. PROTOTYPE.

The first part of the "Take Action" step is not launching immediately into full-scale production. For businesses betting millions of dollars on developing gadgets, apps, and other products, prototyping before production is crucial. Corporate product designers and R&D teams regularly build prototypes to test and refine their ideas, ensuring the final result is something their audience will love. Prototyping saves them time and resources by helping to quickly identify potential problems *before* the final product lands on shelves.

But in activism, unfortunately we've found that prototyping is *rare*. Typically people work on something until it feels like it's fine — or they run out of time or enthusiasm — and then put it out there, with no testing it all.

When you bring up prototyping to your team you may hear, "we don't have time for prototyping," or, "we've already thought through our plan and we know it'll work." But **you can't know how something will play out until you test it out**. And it doesn't have to take long. Prototyping is an exceptionally important, as well as quick and easy, way to make sure everyone you're working with is on the same page and that you've identified and addressed all the kinks you wouldn't see when you're only planning in your head and on paper. Tell those members of your team: **spend time now to save time later**.

We've heard time and time again that integrating prototyping into campaign development processes has been one of the most valuable lessons people have learned from us.

Or, another way we often hear it expressed is: "*[Expletive] [expletive] [expletive]! If I would have just prototyped it . . .*"









Attendees at the Center for Artistic Activism's Making the Impossible Possible convening share prototypes of projects they made in just 20 minutes. Credit: "Making the Impossible Possible," Atlanta, GA, June 2023. Photos by Stephanie Howard Photography.

Prototyping is, again, pretty simple. We can sum it up in just four steps:

1. **Make a rough draft**
2. **Show it to people**
3. **Ask for their feedback**
4. **Make changes**

You can prototype your action by acting it out, or you can test drafts of your action(s) with people outside your campaign through conversation. **Call at least three people** and describe in detail what will happen from the perspective of a participant. Then get their feedback. Better yet, make some quick sketches, a collage of images showing what

you had in mind, or small models. **Then walk through them with your friends** to help them visualize and experience it and get their reactions. Take pictures, videos, and/or notes and share back with your team.

Below are examples of insights that could come from prototyping:

- After playing the part of the passerby, you learn that a small A-Frame sign would help people understand what's happening and the call to action.
- Upon scanning your QR code, you find it doesn't work on some phones and decide to keep key materials in print form as a backup.
- While acting in the role of a volunteer, you notice the beginning of your event moves slowly and feels underwhelming. To counteract the risk of people leaving before things even get underway, you add some rousing chants and activities while everyone assembles.

Do these seem specific? They should—they're all from real campaigns we supported. The campaigners encountered these very issues when they *didn't* prototype these parts of their tactics. The solutions came after the fact. Don't be like them! Instead, prototype. Take what you learn to adjust and improve your plan.

→ Starting to doubt your incredible ideas? You may have hit **The Slump**! Get your confidence back by reading about it at c4aa.org/kit/slump.

BUILT-IN ASSESSMENT

One of the biggest misunderstandings about evaluation is that it is something that happens only *after* you act, as a way to determine if your tactic was a "success" or not. Instead, we **incorporate reflection and evaluation throughout the campaign process**—as you've done throughout this campaign toolkit.

Reflection, evaluation, and iteration are essential for successful advocacy and activism. It's impossible to know how to improve your campaign through iteration without knowing its effect (impact) and affect (emotion), aka the æffect.

As you prepare to launch your action publicly for the first time, you'll also prepare ways to assess its impact. A few methods can make assessment and iteration simple and easy to incorporate into your process.

Decide how you will know if it works. To know whether you've achieved the intended result, you need to measure the effect of your action. You get to decide what metrics are appropriate for your campaign. This means coming up with a set of markers and measurements that can indicate its impact.

Change roles. Where possible while running your tactic, change roles with other people on your team. Your different perspectives, backgrounds, and skills may bring insights, especially when interacting with different audiences. For example, if one person is playing the role of host (welcoming people in, helping them get oriented and comfortable) and another works on providing them with critical information and signing up volunteers for your organization's next action, have them trade places for 15 minutes. By trading places, they may realize that clearer information needs to be communicated earlier, or that a small change can speed up the process.

Step outside and watch. Standing back and observing reactions can reveal how your tactic is having an impact that is not obvious to you while you're working within it. Are people taking notice or passing by? Are they smiling or angry? Talking amongst themselves or lost in thought? You can observe and take notes live, or you can document with video and analyze later. Check out our Action Observation Sheet on the next page to help guide you through this process. With this data, ideas may emerge such as: if we move the balloons five feet to the left, more passersby might stop and look. Then make the change and check the results.

Just ask people. Interviewing participants and passersby is a great way of finding out how your action is impacting your audience. Using the "Think Feel Do" model, ask them what they think and feel about your tactic and what they might do about the issue you're addressing. Interviews can be long or short, and you can find out what your interviewees really think with the tool below:

HOW TO LEARN WHAT PEOPLE REALLY THINK

If you present an idea to people and say, "Whaddya think?!" they'll often say, "That was good!" Polite, but not helpful. Here are questions you can ask instead to get critical feedback that will do a better job at helping you improve your tactic:

- What was surprising?
- What was confusing?
- What made you want to learn more?
- What were you turned off by?
- How would you describe this to a friend?

Come up with your own ways to assess your impact! Design your own evaluation tools to fit your strategies and tactics. Artistic activists have built measurement into their projects with metrics like:

- Creating a comment wall or other methods for people to record their reactions
- Concluding with a speak-out session or conversation
- Organizing a call and response to voice division or unity
- Building interactive props that measure public opinion (e.g., hit the piñata if you're mad and want to see this policy changed)

One advantage of these types of creative evaluation tools is that not only are you collecting information, but you're also immediately sharing it back with your audience.

RESOURCE:

ACTION OBSERVATION SHEET

Use the sheet on the next page to track **how audiences are responding to the different parts of your action in real time**.

Some tips:

- You can tally the number of instances of attention, interest, interactions, etc. as they occur. Or if there's just too much happening, you can do a more general number estimate or check mark.
- This is an example — you can create different rows and columns. For instance, you can make rows for when people are arriving, when they start parading, when singers start singing, when the confetti cannons go off, etc. — adjust to fit your action.

Use the data to see what is or isn't resonating with your audience(s), what you want to do more of, and what you might want to scale back or change in the next iteration.

→ For a digital version of this action observation sheet, head to c4aa.org/kit/observation-sheet.

Time	**Attention** stops and takes notice	**Interest** gets closer/ smiles/ nods/points/ talks to friends	**Uninterest** looks bored or confused	**Anger** looks upset or mad	**Interact** laughs/ claps/calls out	**Participate** asks questions/ joins discussion (note what people say/ ask)	**Document** takes photo/ video
1st Section or 1st 10 minutes							
2nd Section or 2nd 10 minutes							
3rd Section or 3rd 10 minutes							
4th Section or 4th 10 minutes							
5th Section or 5th 10 minutes							
6th Section or 6th 10 minutes							
Observer Name		**Location**		**Date**		**Experiment #**	

MESSAGING AND DOCUMENTATION

MESSAGING MAGIC

Whether you're writing about your campaign on your website, trying to get someone's attention on the street, or figuring out the right framing for a great documentation video that you're putting out about an action you just held, the way you message is key to success.

One messaging framework that has been proven to be especially effective in championing progressive causes (thanks ASO Communications) is VPSA. **VPSA stands for: Value, Problem, Solution, Action.** Let's take each one in turn and then give you an example:

- **Value:** Start with a shared value, something that you know your audience would agree with and that will connect them with people across race and place. Start from a place of positivity and hope.
- **Problem:** Then you can get into the problem—what it is that's preventing that value from being realized, who is the villain in the way, and what they get out of it.
- **Solution:** But it's ok, because you have the answer! Share how we can come together to vanquish the villain, and what it will feel like when we solve the problem.
- **Action:** End with the clear call to action that you've primed your audience for through the previous statements.

Want to see it in action? Here's a VPSA that partners fighting for D.C. statehood came up with during a workshop we led with them:

> *All Americans should have an equal voice in our government.*
>
> *But over 700,000 citizens — the majority of whom are Black and Brown — do not have representation in Congress, and Congress can overturn the local laws that voters pass.*
>
> *Help those thousands of Americans' voices be heard by making D.C. a state.*
>
> *Contact your members of Congress and demand they support D.C. statehood now.*

→ For an exercise to help you walk through these steps for your own campaign, see **Value - Problem - Solution - Action** at c4aa.org/kit/messaging.



Participants in a C4AA workshop in Guinea prototype an anti-corruption action to parody local leaders.

DOCUMENTATION

A frequent oversight is getting your own documentation of your campaign and its impact. **Collecting great photos, video, and testimonials serves you in a variety of ways**. For one, they can help grow and extend the life of a tactic to help you move toward your campaign goals. They also communicate æffectively, attracting momentum and energy to your campaign from the outside world. Documentation can serve the same purpose for your team: they may notice ways your action had an impact that you missed while in the middle of doing it. And of course, quality documentation shows potential funders and other supporters what you're actually doing to bring the vision you all share to life.

For all these reasons, make sure your documentation captures not just *what happened* but the *feeling* of participating or witnessing it live and in-person. Editing, re-framing, narration, captions, and music can all help communicate both the emotionally impactful affect and the practically impactful effect (or what we call the "æffect") of your work. Nearly all smartphones are exceedingly capable of documenting the action or capturing an emotional moment—but when not used well, their footage can be entirely unwatchable. Take stock of your skill level and how available you'll be to compose a beautiful shot or conduct a short interview. Bring on help if you know you can't take it on yourself.

Investing in good documentation can pay for itself because of the excitement it generates in supporters.

Don't count on the press to take your photos or tell your story. Make sure you get the images, video, and statements you'll need. We recommend making a list beforehand of photos you're hoping to capture—portraits of specific people, a group shot, a close up of someone signing their name, people dancing, interviews with passersby turned participants, etc. Give that list to your photographer or videographer.

Great documentation tells your story and helps others share it.

POST-ACTION COLLECTION

It's important to assess the impact of a campaign or project after the fact, too. This additional assessment can provide richer information, as well as insights into its effect over time. Below are a few ideas for post-action information collection. Note that **preparing to do these in advance will often make it easier to collect the information down the line**.

Surveys: Surveys are a good way to know if your action has changed public perception. Ideally, you'll want to survey the same population before and after exposure to your work.

Focus Groups: Bringing together people who've interacted with your campaign and having a conversation about their experience can provide in-depth and valuable information about the impact you had.

Public Records: If your campaign is focused on a specific region, you might be able to examine things like minutes from town hall meetings for positive mentions of your issue, or data like changes in public health statistics, and much, much more. While it can be challenging to isolate the exact effect your campaign may have had on these numbers, if you combine that data with other information you collected it may provide a more comprehensive view of your influence.

Publicity Analysis: Counting and analyzing media mentions—news stories, blog reports, social media posts—is a way of determining how much publicity your campaign has gotten. The quality and tone of that publicity can bring insight, too. Remember, though, that **media is often only a means to an end and may not tell us whether your actions have impacted people or policy**.

POST-ACTION REFLECTION

Did it work?

Once your evaluation data is gathered, you can begin figuring out what it all means. The aim isn't to issue a ruling on its success or failure; rather, it's to **come away with a rich understanding of the tactic — or the campaign overall — and its impact**. The lessons you discover from your work will make the next effort easier, more successful, and more inventive.

The first step to answering the question "Did it work?" is to **generate a thick description of what happened**: a non-judgemental picture of what occurred and what did not. Then you can ask yourself the following key questions to help you analyze it all.

EXERCISE:

DID IT WORK?

30-60 MIN

Review the picture you've gained of your campaign against what you intended. Use your data to ask yourself and your team the following questions. It may be useful to discuss as a group, or for each person to think about the answers on their own and then come back together to share. Either way, make sure to spend at least a few minutes on each question to really get strong, clear, honest answers.

- What worked as expected, and how?
- How effectively did we reach our intended audiences?
- How did the different audiences respond?
- What did they think, feel, and do?
- What sort of political, social, and/or cultural impact did our work have?
- Did we achieve our objective, fall short, or blow past it? Why?

And, because the magic of creativity means not always knowing what will happen:

- What happened that was a surprise?

Finally, because **the ultimate aim is to produce better, more engaging, and more impactful work**, the last step is to learn from the experience and its analysis and move forward, asking:

WHAT'S NEXT?

What could be done differently next time based on everything you've learned? Æffect can be cumulative, with each tactic building off the one before as part of a greater campaign—so how can you build upon this effort in the rest of the work? Spend a moment thinking strategically about your practice and the long-term trajectory.

All in all: **Knowing all you know now, what will you do differently next time?**

→ For an even more detailed set of planning and assessment prompts built upon this framework, head to aeffectapp.org.

CONGRATULATIONS!

You made it to the end of this toolkit, which likely means you took action! Congratulations! Have a party.

Seriously, celebrate every win. Even if you didn't achieve the objective, celebrate that you managed to take steps forward, learned some lessons, and pulled part of it off. **Taking a moment to enjoy what worked well, show appreciation to those who worked alongside you, and rest is what will help you and your team have the energy and vitality for the next challenge.**

This is all a process—and it's also all a practice. **As you keep going, these ideas and ways of thinking will get easier and more natural**. We've seen it happen in the people we've worked with (and we've had it happen to ourselves).

There are many opportunities for innovation and creativity in campaign work. We hope the pages before have inspired you to tap into your innovation and creativity early and often.

And remember: **You're not alone**. You are among clever activists around the world who are innovating, experimenting, learning from successes and shortcomings—both theirs and others'. The activists we've encountered in our work continue to inspire us, and their work—your work—collectively is moving us toward a more utopic life. So, **onward**, as we take more steps together toward the utopia that lives out on the horizon.

This toolkit was developed by the Center for Artistic Activism (C4AA). For more information about the research behind this kit, and more about creative campaigns, see the Center for Artistic Activism's website, c4aa.org. You can get in touch at manager@c4aa.org.

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5 THINGS YOU CAN DO TODAY

This toolkit is full of ideas and exercises to help you do your work more creatively throughout your activist life. Here are five especially important, foundational steps you can take today:

- **Craft clear and specific objectives:** Making robust objectives is a creative process and lays the foundation for infusing creativity into a campaign. Schedule 30 minutes this week to make or revise your objectives for the next three months.

- **Make space and time for creativity and brainstorming:** Great ideas bloom when there's time to break from the routine and relax into dreaming with your team. Make a date in the calendar for everyone to have some "dreaming time" together.

- **Start small but bold**: Create situations where you can experiment with something new, quickly. Prototype, test, and iterate. Include a prototyping phase to your campaign timeline.

- **Seek input from unexpected places:** Invite people outside your field to bring their perspectives. Have a dinner with your collaborators and invite musicians, architects, writers, farmers — you name it. Ask them to reflect on your questions and ideas and how they might approach them.

- **Have fun together:** We don't mean an icebreaker at the start of a meeting. We're talking about making time for the playful, silly, and unexpected. Play paintball. Watch the latest reality TV show. See the #1 box office movie. Go ahead and plan your next outing right now.

Read this toolkit for many more tools to achieve your goals.

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